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SHRI NARENDRA MODI
Honourable Prime Minister of India



FORGING AHEAD STRONGER TOGETHER



LEFT TO RIGHT: Shri Jayanarayan Mishra, Hon'ble MLA - Sambalpur, Shri Tankadhar Tripathy, Hon'ble MLA - Jharsuguda, Shri. Rabi Narayan Naik, Hon'ble Minister of Rural Development, Panchayati Raj, and Drinking Water of Odisha. Shri. Suresh Pujari, Hon'ble Minister of Revenue and Disaster Management of Odisha, H.E. Mr. Keiichi Ono, Ambassador Extraordinary & Plenipotentiary of Japan to India, Shri. Dharmendra Pradhan, Hon'ble Union Minister of Education, GOI, Shri. Mohan Charan Majhi, Hon'ble Chief Minister of Odisha, Mr. Sajjan Jindal, Chairman, JSW Group, Mr. Yoshihisa Kitano, President & CEO, JFE Holdings, Inc., Smt. Anu Garg, Chief Secretary of Odisha, Mr. Parth Jindal, MD, JSW Cement & JSW Paints and Chairman, JSW Dulux, Mr. Jayant Acharya, JMD & CEO, JSW Steel, Mr. Hiroyuki Ogawa, Board Director, JFE Steel Corporation.

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#GetYourSelfPlaced

International delegates get to witness polling in T.N.

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Under the International Election Visitors’ Programme, delegates from various countries witnessed the polling process during the recently concluded Assembly election in the State.

“India is giving the whole world the experience, procedures and knowledge, how to do it [conduct the election]. This is what democracy is...bring the vote to the voter,” High Commissioner of Mauritius to India Sheila-bai Bappoo was quoted as saying in an official press note issued by the Election Commission of India.

She witnessed the polling process at a polling station in Chennai on April 23. The delegates visited Tamil Nadu on April 22 and 23, and observed the systematic movement of polling parties along with election materials through well-planned logistics and established standard operating procedures.

The delegates also interacted with Chief Electoral Officer Archana Patnaik. They were apprised of the overall conduct of elections and the security arrangements in place to ensure a peaceful and smooth process.

“The most important thing I have learned is the minimum assured facilities the ECI and District Election Officer are providing the voters, specifically the help desk and colour coding,” Tshering Samdrup, a delegate from Bhutan, said.

Vijay’s assets: another case in HC questions loan extended to estranged wife Sangeetha

The actor-turned-politician had not properly explained large amounts of loan extended by him to various individuals and entities, says the litigant, a voter from Perambur Assembly constituency

Mohamed Imranullah S.
CHENNAI

One more writ petition has been filed in the Madras High Court, seeking an inquiry into the assets declared by Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) president C. Joseph Vijay while filing his nomination for contesting from the Perambur Assembly constituency in the election held this year.

The new writ petition has been listed for hearing before Chief Justice Sushrut Arvind Dharmadhikari and Justice G. Arul Murugan on Monday (April 27). The Bench had already ordered notice, returnable by June 3, to the Income Tax Department in a similar case filed last week.

The latest case had been filed by M.P. Venkatesh, 32, of Kodungaiyur in Chennai. In his affidavit, the petitioner said that as a voter in the Perambur Assembly constituency, he was entitled to be informed about the financial status of every candidate, and that they were obliged to make truthful disclosures.

He said the disclosures expected to be made by the candidates in Form 26 were not an empty ritual or formality, but a substantive constitutional obligation. Any suppression, concealment, misstatement or manipulation of



A bare reading of Vijay's election affidavit discloses a “disturbing and consistent pattern of suppression, misrepresentation and financial obfuscation”, the petitioner alleged. FILE PHOTO

material particulars would amount to a fraud on the electoral process, he added.

Pointing out that Mr. Vijay had projected himself as a proponent of clean and transparent politics, the petitioner said: “However, his own disclosures in the 2026 nomination affidavit reveal substantial financial dealings, including high value loans extended to family members and closely connected entities, which have triggered serious public concern and scrutiny.”

He went on to state: “The disclosure of a ₹12.6 crore loan to his spouse, Sangeetha, has assumed greater significance in the light of widely reported developments concerning matrimonial disputes, thereby raising legitimate

questions about the genuineness, purpose and characterization of such transactions.”

Further, referring to affidavit disclosures regarding loans extended to various other individuals and entities, the petitioner said: “The fifth respondent (Mr. Vijay) has simultaneously declared zero liabilities and no outstanding dues, thereby projecting an artificially sanitized and misleading financial profile. Such contradictory disclosures, including large transfers such as ₹20 crore to the Kokilambal Educational Trust, are neither properly explained nor truthfully presented.”

Alleging that a bare reading of the election affidavit discloses a “disturbing and consistent pattern

of suppression, misrepresentation and financial obfuscation”, the petitioner sought an inquiry into the issue by the Election Commission of India as well as the Director General of Income Tax (Investigation).

Two other cases

The Chief Justice’s Bench would hear on Monday two more cases of a similar nature, regarding the assets disclosed in the election affidavits of the AIADMK’s former Ministers, D. Jayakumar and C. Ve. Shanmugam, who contested the election from the Royapuram and Maimlam constituencies, respectively.

The first case against Mr. Vijay had been filed by V. Vignesh, another voter from the Perambur Assembly constituency, who alleged that there was a difference of over ₹100 crore in the assets declared by the TVK leader in the affidavits he had submitted before the Returning Officers in the Perambur and Tiruchi East Assembly constituencies, since he was contesting from two constituencies.

However, that petitioner had not submitted in the court the amended affidavits that had been accepted by the Returning Officer of the Perambur constituency, and had instead relied only on a rejected affidavit.

Two gaurs die, two calves rescued after falling into well in Manapparai forest range



Fatal fall: The carcass of a gaur being lifted from a well at Karuppur village in the Manapparai forest range on Sunday. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

R. Rajaram
TIRUCHI

Four gaurs, including two calves, fell into a farmwell at Karuppur village in Manapparai forest range in Tiruchi district on Saturday night. Two of them were found dead, while the other two – both calves – were rescued by a team of field-level personnel from the Forest Department and the Fire and Rescue Services on Sunday.

The four animals fell into the well around 8.15 p.m. on Saturday. Forest Department officials inspected the well on being alerted by the residents. The nearly 80-foot-deep well had about 10 feet of water. Initially, three gaurs were spotted on Saturday night. The fourth animal was noticed on Sunday, a Forest Department official said, and added that one

gaur was dead, and its carcass was floating in the water.

The operation was launched in the early hours of Sunday by the joint team, after mobilising necessary material. A team of veterinarians was present. R. Kanchana, Conservator of Forests, Tiruchi Circle, monitored the rescue operation.

First, the water was drained from the well using a motor. A crane was brought to the spot. The two dead animals were found to be male, with one aged four and the other three. They had apparently died in the impact of the fall. The carcasses were lifted with a crane.

The team managed to rescue two calves – both around one-and-a-half years old – from the well. The operation lasted six hours, the officials said. The condition of the two

rescued calves was assessed by the veterinarians. The calves were given medications before being released.

An autopsy was performed on the two dead animals at the nearby Karuppureddipatti reserve forest, and they were buried thereafter.

The officials suspect that the four animals may have strayed into the area before falling into the open well at night.

The Manapparai and adjoining Thuvrankurichi forest ranges in Tiruchi district have a sizeable number of gaurs, which are constantly on the move, especially at night. There have also been earlier instances of gaurs and other animals having fallen into open wells in the vicinity of the reserve forests in the Manapparai and Thuvrankurichi forest ranges.

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Harilal Bhaskar

For a long time, doctoral research was guided by a simple expectation: think harder than anyone else about a narrowly defined problem and prove it through writing. The thesis became the ultimate marker of intellectual maturity; a document that signalled depth, discipline, and originality.

That expectation was not misguided. It was appropriate for its time. But the conditions under which it evolved have changed faster than the system that upholds it. The challenge confronting societies today is not a shortage of ideas. It is the slow and uncertain journey from ideas to functioning solutions. Knowledge circulates freely; usable capability does not. The distance increasingly determines whether nations lead or follow.

Conversion problem

This gap is where doctoral education now finds itself exposed. Across key sectors – energy systems, advanced manufacturing, artificial intelligence, health technologies, climate adaptation – the limiting factor is no longer theoretical understanding but the ability to convert insight into something that works reliably outside controlled environments. Doctoral training sits at the centre of this conversion problem.

Over time, the Ph.D. has become exceptionally good at producing publica-

Beyond the thesis

If doctoral research stops at writing and never reaches real-world application, can it truly claim to create impact?

tions and measurable academic novelty. What it produces far less consistently are systems that can be deployed, tested under real conditions, and sustained at scale. This is not an indictment of researchers. It is the predictable outcome of evaluation structures that prioritise articulation over application.

The real issue, therefore, is not talent. It is alignment. A thesis demonstrates that a scholar understands a problem in depth. It does not demonstrate that the problem can be solved under constraints, adapted to context, or carried forward by others. In a slower era, that distinction was tolerable. Today, it is decisive.

Technological advantage is now measured in compressed timelines. Countries that shorten the path from research to deployment gain leverage. Those that do not, irrespective of academic output, become dependent on external systems to operationalise their own ideas. This reality demands a rethink of what doctoral achievement represents.

New parameters

Writing cannot remain the sole endpoint. The future of doctoral work must be judged by responsibility for outcomes; by whether

research survives interaction with real users, real environments, and real failure modes. This does not mean sidelining theory or abandoning fundamental inquiry. Foundational science remains essential. But treating a written document as the only legitimate proof of doctoral merit no longer reflects how knowledge creates value in the world.

What is needed is an additional doctoral pathway: one that evaluates construction alongside comprehension. Where candidates are assessed on how systems perform, how results can be reproduced, and how solutions behave beyond the laboratory. In such a model, writing still

matters but as documentation of something that exists and functions, not as a substitute for it. This raises standards rather than lowering them.

Explaining an idea is demanding. Making it work, repeatedly and reliably, is harder. For researchers, such a shift is not a threat. It broadens what counts as excellence. It allows doctoral work to escape the narrow life-cycle of journals and enter longer, more consequential trajectories. It acknowledges forms of intelligence that academia has often undervalued: systems thinking, integration, and execution under pressure.

For institutions, however, it is unsettling. It requires new evaluation norms, collaboration beyond disciplinary boundaries, and closer engagement with industry, public systems, and mission-oriented programmes. It forces a reconsideration of what advanced education is ultimately meant to serve.

Is the purpose of a Ph.D. to certify intellectual capability alone or to strengthen collective capacity? These goals are not contradictory. But in the current context, treating them as separate has become untenable. India, especially, faces this choice at a critical moment. Investments in shared research facilities, national technology platforms, and strategic sectors are expanding. Without corresponding evolution in doctoral training,

the country risks producing sophisticated knowledge that remains detached from deployment pathways. Doctoral education should amplify national capability, not delay it.

The researcher of the future will still value rigour, question assumptions, and pursue depth. But they will also build, test, iterate, and deliver under real conditions. The decisive question will not be how impressive a thesis reads. It will be whether the research altered what could be done. If doctoral systems cannot answer that question with confidence, reform is not a matter of preference. It is unavoidable.

The writer is COO and National Coordinator at I-STEM under the Office of Principal Scientific Adviser (P.S.A.) Government of India.

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Courtesy: Buddy4study.com

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From Page One

Helicopters deployed as forest fire spreads across the Nilgiris



Battling the blaze: More than 400 Forest Department personnel were roped in from across Tamil Nadu to put out the fire. M. SATHYAMOORTHY

The Collector made the request to the Tamil Nadu State Disaster Management Authority. An Air Force team from Sulur conducted aerial reconnaissance, and was helping in dousing the fire using a helicopter, the release added. Forest Department officials said the department was fighting multiple fires in the Singara and Masinagudi Forest Ranges in the MTR as well as those in Parson’s Valley.

‘Retaliation against inaction’
They believe the fires were started by people, possibly in retaliation for the perceived inaction on the part of the Forest Department after the killing of three persons by tigers in The Nilgiris last year. The Forest Department has warned communities residing near the reserve forests against starting fires. In Mudumalai, the fires might have been started by herders clearing dry grass for regeneration of cattle fodder, according to officials.

Palacode, Veerapandi and Kulithalai frontrunners in voter turnout since 2011

They saw high turnout in every Assembly poll held in the State since the 2008 delimitation. This is due to several factors, including political mobilisation on communal lines and local-level loyalties

N. Sai Charan
CHENNAI

Three Assembly segments – Palacode in Dharmapuri district, Veerapandi in Salem district, and Kulithalai in Karur district – have remained perennial toppers, featuring in the top five in terms of voter turnout in every Assembly election held since the delimitation of Tamil Nadu’s constituencies in 2008.

The State’s overall voter turnout has fluctuated over the years, from 78.29% in 2011 to 74.84% in 2016 and 73.51% in 2021 (held amid the COVID-19 pandemic), before surging to 85.15% in 2026 after the Special Intensive Revision of the electoral roll. While several Assembly segments witnessed drastic changes in voter turnout in these elections, Palacode, Veerapandi, and Kulithalai retained their positions at the top, irrespective of the Statewide trend.



Ranking high: Kulithalai, which falls in the central region, stood second in the State in terms of voter turnout in 2011. FILE PHOTO

Several factors have contributed to the consistently high voter turnout in these segments. They include political mobilisation on communal lines as well as local-level loyalties. In the 2026 election, Veerapandi recorded the second highest voter turnout in Tamil Nadu at 93.36%, following Karur (94.41%). It topped the State in 2011 with 89.16% and ranked fourth in both the 2016 (86.74%) and the 2021 elections (86.43%). Veerapandi was once a stronghold of late DMK

90.57% and ranked fifth. The constituency remains a stronghold of former AIADMK Minister K.P. Anbalagan, who has been winning the seat since 2001. He is among the few MLAs in Tamil Nadu to have been elected consecutively from the same constituency. In an attempt to challenge his dominance, the DMK has fielded D.N.V. Senthilkumar, former Dharmapuri Lok Sabha member, against him. Unlike the other two Assembly segments in western Tamil Nadu, Kulithalai, which falls in the central region, ranked second in the State in terms of voter turnout in 2011 (88.83%), 2016 (88.16%), and 2021 (87.21%), before slipping to the third place in 2026, despite recording 92.8%. Former Chief Minister M. Karunanidhi was first elected to the Assembly from Kulithalai in 1957. Over the decades, the seat has alternated between the DMK and the AIADMK. In 2026, it recorded

Six Forest Dept. staff, DSP assaulted after man dies in elephant attack in Gudalur

The Hindu Bureau
UDHAGAMANDALAM

Six Forest Department staff sustained injuries after being assaulted by an angry mob, when they were attempting to retrieve the body of a man who died in an elephant attack at O’Valley in Gudalur late on Saturday night.

The deceased was identified as T. Kalaiselvan, 45. He was part of a team tasked with preparing meals for a temple festival being held in the area. He was attacked by the elephant when he went to fetch water from a well near a wooded area. Hearing his cries, residents rushed to his aid, but were unable to rescue him. They staged a protest and prevented the Forest Department staff from retrieving his body and sending it for a post-mortem. As tensions rose, some of the protesters allegedly attacked the department staff and their vehicles, saying they failed to protect the lives of the local residents. In the attack, six temporary staff members of

Protesters allegedly attacked the Forest Department staff and their vehicles, saying they failed to protect the lives of local residents

the Forest Department sustained injuries. Among them, Rajesh, 50, suffered a broken hand. A Deputy Superintendent of Police was also assaulted, officials said.

Two arrested
The New Hope police registered a case following the incident. They have since arrested two people, identified as K. Arumugam, 40, and C. Manikandan, 29, and are on the lookout for four others. After extensive negotiations, the protesters dispersed at around 3 a.m. on Sunday. The department has released an interim compensation of ₹50,000 for the next of kin of the deceased. Special teams have been formed to prevent human-elephant conflicts in the region.

Railways orders audit of signalling systems to ensure safe operations

S. Vijay Kumar
CHENNAI

The Indian Railways has ordered an audit of the signalling systems across its network to rectify deficiencies and improve the overall reliability of the critical assets for ensuring safe train operations. Directing the general managers of all zonal railways to depute senior officers to conduct the audit, the Railway Board said in a safety advisory that it was essential to ensure the quality of newly commissioned installations and periodically review the existing/old systems to assess their reliability. The instruction comes in the backdrop of many fatal accidents or derailments in the last three years, in which the failure of signals, especially in the automatic signalling territory, was suspected to be the reason. In at least two incidents, including the accident in



The instruction comes in the backdrop of many fatal accidents or derailments in the last three years, in which the failure of signals was suspected to be the reason. FILE PHOTO

volving the Shalimar-Chennai Coromandel Express in South Eastern Railway on June 2, 2023, which left about 290 passengers dead and 900 others injured, signals were in the green for speeding trains to run on the main line, but the points were set to the loop line. The advisory said the audit must cover the quality of installation and adherence to approved draw-

ings and specifications, compliance with the Technical Advisory Note issued by the Research Design and Standards Organisation, the condition of equipment, wiring, earthing, and bonding, which were imperative for the effective functioning of the signalling systems. “The objective of the audit is to identify faulty systems, ensure compliance with the prescribed stan-

dards, and improve the reliability of the signalling installations,” a senior railway officer said, adding that the records of audit reports would be maintained by the zonal railways for review. The Railways has also directed the general managers to conduct root-cause analysis of asset failures at the divisional level. “It is important that asset failures are investigated to arrive at the root cause. The divisional railway managers shall make sure that a detailed root-cause analysis of asset failures in their jurisdictions is done on a regular basis,” the Railway Board said in an order issued last week. The Railway Board Chairman and Chief Executive Officer would review the reports of asset failures by interacting with the divisional railway managers and their teams through video-conference and discuss the root-cause of such failures.

Research finds high microplastic contamination in mangrove fish

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

A study reveals that the mangrove ecosystem of Pichavaram is experiencing “high contamination” of microplastics in fish and shellfish, raising ecological risks in the region. The research, conducted by Bharathidasan University and published in *Chemosphere*, examines seasonal patterns of microplastic ingestion in aquatic species. It noted that these particles, originating from degraded plastic waste and synthetic materials, are “pervasive pollutants in aquatic ecosystems”, and are being consumed by a wide range of organisms. According to the study, microplastic levels vary significantly across seasons, with the highest (around 45%) recorded during the monsoon. This spike is attributed to increased runoff and plastic inflow during heavy rains, which



Toxic threat: According to the study, microplastic levels vary significantly across seasons, with the highest (around 45%) recorded during the monsoon. FILE PHOTO

The study highlights the need for targeted strategies to reduce pollution and its impact on marine life

transport debris into the mangrove environment. The findings show that fish such as Rock Mullet (*Liza tade*) and Pearl Spot (*Etroplus suratensis*), along

with shellfish such as *Portunus sanguinolentus* and *Scylla serrata*, exhibit notable ingestion levels. In *Liza tade*, for instance, microplastic counts varied across seasons, reflecting how exposure changes with environmental conditions. A significant share of detected particles – about 32% – measured less than one millimetre, indicating

high bio-availability. Fibres dominated the samples, with blue (around 40%) and red among the most common colours. Polymer analysis identified polyethylene, polypropylene, and polyethylene terephthalate as the primary materials. The study explained that mangrove ecosystems act as “natural bio-filters”, trapping microplastics through their dense root systems and sedimentation processes. This high retention capacity allows plastics to accumulate and persist for long periods, increasing the likelihood of ingestion by aquatic organisms and their movement through the food web. The research highlighted the “pervasive nature” and complex seasonal behaviour of microplastics in Pichavaram, and called attention to their ecological implications. It also highlighted the need for targeted strategies to reduce pollution and its impact on marine life.

Panaiyur fossil assemblage dates back to Holocene period: study

Shankari Nivethitha B.
THOOTHUKUDI

A paleontological assessment of fossil assemblage at Panaiyur in Thoothukudi district reveals that it belongs to the middle to late Holocene period, approximately 8,000 to 12,000 years ago. The technical report of the assessment by the Zoological Survey of India (ZSI) was authored by its scientific team comprising Dola Roy, Debashree Dam, R. Chandran, C. Raghunathan, and Dhriti Banerjee. The team visited the site last January and conducted a detailed study of these fossils. The study stemmed from a letter sent by former Thoothukudi Collector K. Elambahavath to the ZSI, after a local archaeology enthusiast, Rajesh Selvarathi, discovered the site

located around 25 km from Thoothukudi.

Age estimate
According to the report, the tentative age was determined based on the stratigraphic position, sedimentological context, degree of fossilisation, and comparison with dated quaternary deposits from the region. Several lines of evidence support this age estimate. One of the key factors is species composition, which consists entirely of extant taxa with modern distributions in the Gulf of Mannar, suggesting relatively recent depositions rather than ancient assemblages. Another factor is the nature of sedimentary facies (sandy to silty sediments with shell concentrations), which are typical Holocene coastal and estuarine de-

posits formed during sea-level highstands. The report states that the finding adds to the limited inventory of Quaternary fossil sites in Tamil Nadu and provides new data for understanding coastal evolution in the Gulf of Mannar region. Additionally, the recovery of 104 specimens representing four taxonomic groups, which includes three bivalve taxa and one gastropod family, demonstrates a moderately diverse molluscan community. According to the report, the identified fossil taxa are extant species or genera found in the Gulf of Mannar and adjacent waters. The morphological similarity between the fossil and modern specimens, combined with the absence of extinct species, indicates remarkable environmental

continuity over the past several thousand years. “This suggests that the fundamental oceanographic, climatic, and ecological conditions of the Gulf of Mannar have remained relatively stable throughout the Holocene period, despite fluctuations in sea level and coastal configuration,” the report said. The assemblage also indicates shallow marine to estuarine setting with mixed sandy-muddy substrates, moderate water circulation, marine to brackish salinity, and warm tropical temperatures. Referring to this fossil assemblage, Sudhakar Sivabramaniam, Head (in-charge), Department of Archaeology, Manonmaniam Sundaranar University, said the structures were exposed due to soil erosion during the floods that hit Thoothukudi in 2023.

He said similar assemblages could be found from Panaiyur to Manappad, though intentional excavation would require significant financial investment. He added that around three to four acres of land in Panaiyur exposed the fossil assemblage and that nearby areas could be excavated and developed for public exhibition. Mr. Chandran from ZSI said the preliminary study was limited to already exposed areas. He said if further excavations were undertaken at the request of the Tamil Nadu government, more significant findings could emerge. He further said the position of the fossil locality in Panaiyur, which is situated around 5 km from the coastline, suggests changes in the coastal configuration during the Holocene period.



Rocky remains: A view of the fossil assemblage from approximately 8,000 to 12,000 years ago, at the site in Panaiyur in Thoothukudi district. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



Long wait for consumers: Petrol sales rose to 10,345 kl and diesel to 14,156 kl in the State on Saturday. G.N. RAO

Restore normal fuel supply by today, Naidu asks officials

The Hindu Bureau
VIJAYAWADA

Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister N. Chandrababu Naidu on Sunday directed officials and oil company representatives to immediately step up petrol and diesel supplies across the State, with a target to restore normalcy by Monday.

Reviewing the situation through a teleconference from his camp office, the Chief Minister was informed that a sudden surge in demand, partly due to bulk purchases by commercial consumers at retail outlets, had strained supplies. Petrol sales, which usually average 6,330 kilolitres per day, rose by 34% to 8,489 kilolitres on Saturday and remained 22% higher than normal on Sunday.

Diesel sales also increased, climbing from a daily average of 9,048 kilolitres to 10,556 kilolitres on Saturday, adding to pressure on supply systems.

Officials said the State has 4,510 fuel outlets, of

which about 10%, or 421 petrol bunks, had shut down due to lack of stock. Fuel supply, they said, was already 10% higher than normal levels, but panic buying by consumers triggered an unexpected surge in demand, resulting in long queues and rapid depletion of stocks at many outlets.

Mr. Naidu said panic buying was aggravating the situation and causing inconvenience to the public, and directed officials to ensure that people did not face hardship from a fuel shortage. Officials also flagged supply constraints in the aquaculture sector, where diesel is often procured in bulk in drums, adding to logistical pressure. The Chief Minister directed the District Collectors and Fisheries Department officials to prepare a coordinated plan to ensure that routine economic activity is not disrupted. Mr. Naidu asked officials to submit a detailed report on measures taken, and progress, in easing the situation.

Will abide by directions of high command: Shivakumar

Amid leadership speculation, Karnataka Deputy CM says Siddaramaiah and he 'have faith' in the Congress top brass and that an appropriate decision will be taken at the right time

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

A day after returning from Delhi, Karnataka Deputy Chief Minister D.K. Shivakumar on Sunday said that he and Chief Minister Siddaramaiah would abide by the Congress high command's decision on leadership in the government.

Speaking to press persons, Mr. Shivakumar said he had full faith in the party leadership and that an appropriate decision would be taken at the right time. "Both the Chief Minister and I have said that we will follow the high command's instructions and act accordingly," he



There has been speculation about a possible leadership change and Cabinet reshuffle in Karnataka in May. FILE PHOTO

said. During his three-day stay in the national capital, Mr. Shivakumar met All India Congress Committee president Mallikarjun Kharge and AICC general secretary K.C. Venugopal

and reportedly sought clarity from them on the matter of leadership change.

There has been speculation about a possible leadership change and Cabinet reshuffle next month.

The results of the Assembly elections in four States and one Union Territory will be declared on May 4, along with byelections to two Assembly constituencies in Karnataka. After May 4, the party high command is expected to summon both Mr. Siddaramaiah and Mr. Shivakumar for discussions on issues related to leadership, the Cabinet, and the KPCC president's post.

Responding to a query on Minister Satish Jarkiholi's remarks about confusion in the party, he said, "Our party will take the necessary decisions at the right time, we have faith in our leadership; they know what needs to be done."

Ten workers seriously injured as rail overbridge collapses in Visakhapatnam



The collapsed portion of an under-construction overbridge at Auto Nagar in Visakhapatnam on Sunday. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

The Hindu Bureau
VISAKHAPATNAM

Ten workers were seriously injured when a portion of an under-construction rail overbridge collapsed at Vadlapudi in Visakhapatnam city, Andhra Pradesh, on Sunday. They were rushed to nearby hospitals. Doctors said their condition was stable.

The bridge, under the control of the State government, is aimed at connecting Auto Nagar and Duvva-

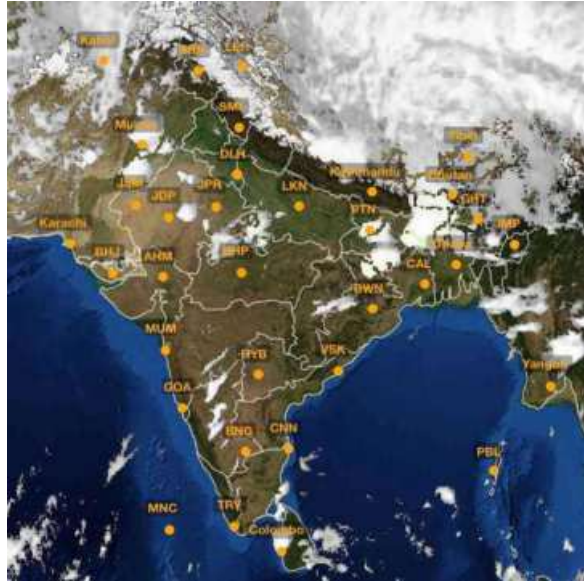
da. Work on it has picked up pace of late as it is a long-pending demand of the residents of Auto Nagar, Vadlapudi, Duvvada and Kurmannapalem.

The Gajuwaka police registered a case.

Roads & Buildings Minister B.C. Janardhan Reddy, who is currently on an official visit to Singapore, said strict action would be taken against the contractor concerned if negligence was found to be the reason behind the accident.

WEATHERWATCH

Rainfall, temperature & air quality in select metros yesterday



Forecast for Monday: Heavy to very heavy rainfall very likely at isolated places over Arunachal Pradesh and Assam and Meghalaya. Heavy rainfall very likely at isolated places over Nagaland, Manipur, Mizoram, Tripura and West Bengal and Sikkim.

CITY	RAIN	MAX	MIN	CITY	RAIN	MAX	MIN
Agartala		33.5	21.6	Kozhikode		37.2	29.3
Ahmedabad		44.8	28.2	Kurnool		43.2	29.7
Aizawl		50	30.2	Lucknow		43.0	43.0
Allahabad		45.7	26.3	Madurai		40.0	26.1
Bengaluru		36.0	24.8	Mangaluru		34.7	27.1
Bhopal		43.0	25.2	Mumbai		34.4	26.5
Bhubaneswar		35.5	26.5	Mysuru		36.2	21.4
Chandigarh		40.8	22.4	New Delhi		43.1	27.1
Chennai		38.6	27.6	Patna		34.4	27.6
Coimbatore		38.4	25.4	Port Blair		32.8	27.0
Dehradun		39.2	22.5	Puducherry		34.5	25.0
Gangtok		1.0	16.0	Pune		42.9	25.9
Goa				Raipur		44.2	28.3
Guwahati		3.0	28.0	Ranchi		40.2	25.0
Hubballi		38.0	23.0	Shillong		16.3	12.1
Hyderabad		40.6	28.4	Shimla		31.5	20.0
Imphal		6.5	26.3	Srinagar		1.0	26.4
Jaipur				Thiruvananthapuram		34.2	27.6
Kochi		33.2	28.6	Tiruchi		39.1	26.6
Kohima				Vijayawada			
Kolkata		33.6	27.4	Visakhapatnam		32.6	27.3

CITIES	SO ₂	NO ₂	CO	PM2.5	PM10	CODE	Yesterday
Ahmedabad		36	377	12		81	In observation made at 4.00 p.m., Singrauli,
Bengaluru		14	55	20		66	
Chennai		4	3	30		57	
Delhi		49	129	40		232	
Hyderabad		16	15	35		66	
Kolkata		13	27	20		31	
Lucknow		13	30	19		220	
Mumbai		5	24	28		77	
Pune		23	100		50	70	
Visakhapatnam		34	52	26		34	

Air Quality Code: ■ Poor ■ Moderate ■ Good (Readings indicate average AQI)
SO₂: Sulphur Dioxide. Short-term exposure can harm the respiratory system, making breathing difficult. It can affect visibility by reacting with other air particles to form haze and stain culturally important objects such as statues and monuments.
NO₂: Nitrogen Dioxide. Aggravates respiratory illness, causes haze to form by reacting with other air particles, causes acid rain, pollutes coastal waters.
CO: Carbon monoxide. High concentration in air reduces oxygen supply to critical organs like the heart and brain. At very high levels, it can cause dizziness, confusion, unconsciousness and even death.
PM2.5 & PM10: Particulate matter pollution can cause irritation of the eyes, nose and throat, coughing, chest tightness and shortness of breath, reduced lung function, irregular heartbeat, asthma attacks, heart attacks and premature death in people with heart or lung disease

Heat, grief make way for customary grandeur as Kerala holds scaled-down Thrissur Pooram

Mini Muringatheri
THRISSUR

The scorching sun was harsher than ever, the humidity was unbearable, and there was a sense of gloom in the air. Yet, Thrissur Pooram unfolded in all its splendour on Sunday.

Deeply rooted in tradition yet vibrant in festive energy, the annual festival in Kerala is a unique blend of rituals, percussion, and grand elephant processions. It signifies the symbolic meeting of deities of 10 famous temples in the region with the main participants being the deities of Paramakkavu and Thiruvambady temples.

Following the fireworks tragedy at Mundathikode that claimed 15 lives, authorities had decided to hold this year's event without fireworks. While all other



Majestic tradition: Crowds gathered to witness the traditional Kudamattam as part of the Thrissur Pooram in front of Sree Vadakkunnathan Temple at the Thekkinkadu Maidan on Sunday. K.K. NAJEEB

major rituals were retained, the Kudamattam was curtailed to just 15 minutes, with just 10 sets of parasols to be displayed.

The scaled-down format did not deter people, determined to make the most of what remained and keep the spirit of the festival vi-

brant, from thronging Thekkinkadu Maidan. As the trumpets roared, and richly adorned elephants strode in royal procession,

people plunged headlong into the festival mood.

Emotional bond

Deities were brought on caparisoned elephants to Sree Vadakkunnathan Temple, with their convergence offering a breathtaking sight, while the percussion ensembles by some of finest in the State woke up the rhythm in the people's heart. The deep emotional bond the festival has with people of Thrissur and beyond explains the crowd that gathered under a cloud of grief that hung over the proceedings.

As artiste Nanda Kishore put it, "We stand here with pain in our hearts. But we cannot turn away from festivals. Poorams and celebrations bridge distances between people... lighten our hearts. That is why these festivals must go on."

'Karnataka Minister on life support, may need lung transplant'

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

Doctors attending to D. Sudhakar, Minister for Planning and Statistics of Karnataka, say that if his lungs do not show significant improvement, he may be considered for lung transplantation.

Mr. Sudhakar, who had developed a lung infection, is receiving intensive medical care at KIMS Hospitals (Krishna Institute of Medical Science), Electronic City, Bengaluru.

sued on Sunday, doctors said at present he was stable on life support.

Continuous observation "Currently he is on full life support to assist his vital organ functions. A specialised multidisciplinary team of expert doctors, is monitoring his condition round the clock... if his lungs does not show significant improvement he may be considered for lung transplantation," said Dr. Pavan Yadav M.V., Clinical Director, Interventional Pulmonology at KIMS.

Upgraded SARPA platform to boost snakebite care in Kerala

Sarath Babu George
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

Amid a rise in snakebite cases in Kerala during the ongoing heat wave, the State Forest Department is set to roll out an upgraded version of its snake-response platform, SARPA, aimed at strengthening emergency response and reducing fatalities.

The Snake Awareness, Rescue and Protection App (SARPA) has played a crucial role in recent years by coordinating snake rescues, enabling users to report sightings, and providing details of trained

responders and nearby healthcare facilities. The platform has been credited with improving response times.

The proposed upgrade comes against the backdrop of a spike in snakebite cases, which officials and experts link to the present spell of extreme heat. Kerala has reported four fatalities from snakebites last week.

According to official sources, SARPA is being redesigned to address deficiencies in emergency care by integrating a network of medical professionals and snake experts into the plat-

form. This will allow first responders to access verified and real-time guidance during the crucial minutes following a snakebite.

One of the persistent challenges in snakebite management is the difficulty in identifying the species involved, which often leads to hesitation in administering anti-snake venom or uncertainty about the correct dosage.

The upgraded application will include dedicated login access for doctors, which will enable them to guide first-response measures remotely until specialised care is reached.

Visually challenged trainee judge gets an inclusive campus



Thanya Nathan C., Kerala's first visually challenged trainee judge, at the Kerala Judicial Academy on Sunday. THULASI KAKKAT

K.S. Sudhi
KOCHI

Hostel room number 110 on the ground floor of the Kerala Judicial Academy at Athani in Ernakulam has been spruced up for a new occupant.

Two stainless steel grab bars have been fixed along the wall of the room to guide Thanya Nathan C., the first visually challenged trainee judge in the district judiciary of Kerala, who checked into the hostel on Sunday, from the door to the bed. The bathroom has been modified to cater to the needs of its occupant. Ms. Nathan will be accompanied by her mother, C.H. Babitha, with permission from the academy which will be covering the expenses.

The academy premises have been modified to ensure unobstructed movement for Ms. Nathan with newly built ramps and tactile paving to guide her along the path. A walkway encircling the courtyard with a fully grown flowering tree has been secured with chains to prevent any accidental fall.

"I need a companion to move outside the room, though I quickly get accus-

tomed to the interiors of the rooms where I am staying. It is for the first time that I am staying in a hostel room," Ms. Nathan said.

While service of a woman attendant will be made available for Ms. Nathan, her fellow trainees will be put on a weekly rotation to help her complete her academic work. It will be a learning opportunity for other trainees, said K.N. Sujith, Director of the academy.

Ms. Nathan may miss the "walk the talk" programme where the trainees take a stroll along the campus with senior judges. However, plans are afoot to set up the required facilities for the programme.

Some of the proposals to make the campus fully inclusive, which had to be put on hold during the Assembly election, will be revived once the Model Code of Conduct is lifted. Purchasing of software for trainees with special needs is in the pipeline, Mr. Sujith added.

The year-long training programme for Ms. Nathan and her fellow trainees will commence on Monday with an induction ceremony at 11 a.m.

Telangana CM seeks refresh of grievance redress app

The Hindu Bureau
HYDERABAD

Directing officials to strengthen Prajavani, the platform enabling people in Telangana to register their grievances for timely solutions, Chief Minister A. Revanth Reddy has asked them to decentralise the system so that people at the grassroots levels are able to register their complaints.

Mr. Reddy gave the instructions during a meeting with senior officials headed by Chief Secretary K. Ramakrishna Rao on Sunday. He wanted Prajavani to be extended to the revenue division level with immediate effect and to mandal level in the coming days.

Prajavani, launched a few days after the Congress took over the reins of the State in December 2023, has ensured speedy redress of grievances. Senior officials receive complaints every Friday and take steps for their expeditious redress. A similar mechanism has been functioning at the district level, where Collectors conduct Prajavani weekly.

The Chief Secretary was asked to give adequate powers to officials at different levels to resolve the complaints lodged during Prajavani.

All the complaints should be registered and sent to the departments, and the applicants should be informed about the status of their representation from time to time.

Grievances should be resolved in a time-bound manner and there should not be any delays in addressing the issues raised by the people.



Turning point

The U.S. is slicing away at India's ability to pursue an independent foreign policy

The U.S. has allowed its waiver of sanctions on Iran's Chabahar port to lapse on Sunday (April 26), indicating that India is now at a crossroads on how to proceed with the port as a key connectivity initiative. Barring a belated waiver renewal, New Delhi must choose between accepting sanctions and abandoning its \$620 million investment, or proceeding with the project and risk strict U.S. sanctions. India's "start-stop" engagement with Iran on developing a facility at the Shahid Beheshti terminal at Chabahar goes back decades, and Prime Minister A.B. Vajpayee signed an MoU for the project in 2003. However, U.S. pressure on India to postpone plans aimed at stopping Iran's nuclear programme led to construction delays. The Manmohan Singh government was unable to make much progress either, but continued work on the Zaranj-Delaram highway to connect the Iran-Afghanistan border crossing to Kabul. After the 2015 JCPOA, Prime Minister Narendra Modi's government signed a trilateral agreement with Iran and Afghanistan to advance trade and aid via Chabahar port and a highway into Afghanistan. Chabahar's importance grew as ties with Pakistan deteriorated and it restricted India's transit access to Afghanistan. However, fate intervened again as U.S. President Donald Trump walked out of the JCPOA, and began a "maximum pressure" campaign against Iran by re-implementing all sanctions. While India was forced by the U.S. to give up Iranian oil imports, and plans for the rail line, the U.S. built a "carve-out" for Chabahar, allowing India to send wheat and medical supplies to Afghanistan. That carve-out is now at an end, with the Trump administration giving Delhi until this month to "wind-down" its operations. Since November 2025, India has withdrawn personnel from Chabahar, prepaid its \$120 million investment commitment, and is considering transferring its stake in the Shahid Beheshti Terminal to an Iranian company, with the option of returning later.

The West Asia war has complicated the situation, and it is unclear when, if ever, India will be able to re-engage with Iran or rebuild Chabahar after the conflict. Temporarily dropping the project may seem pragmatic. However, Chabahar is just one of several India's independent decisions that the U.S. has thwarted; there have been dictates to stop buying oil from Iran, Venezuela, and Russia. Mr. Trump has threatened sanctions on all trade with Iran, and on BRICS grouping members; the U.S.'s seemingly insatiable demands may also extend to India's engagement with other countries. Giving in on Chabahar will not just end India's connectivity plans with Iran, Central Asia and Afghanistan. It will damage its claims of sovereign autonomy, and slice away its ability to pursue an independent foreign policy.

Tough call

India needs to develop rapid venom detection diagnostics

A combination of snakes being ectothermic, a hotter summer than usual, difficult decision-making, and gaps in clinical infrastructure has led to a situation in Kerala where the availability of anti-snake venom (ASV) has not been able to prevent all deaths from snakebites. Snakes are driven by the heat to seek refuge in cool, damp spaces, which means homes and storerooms with firewood and coconut husks. The State is also densely vegetated with substantial human-wildlife range overlap. April-May is also the pre-monsoon breeding season for many venomous snakes, which means that they move around more and tend to be defensive. However, about 70% of snakebite presentations involve non-venomous species, and roughly half of the rest are dry bites with no venom injected. A substantial number of patients thus do not warrant ASV. Caution against administering ASV willy-nilly is merited because these compounds can also induce anaphylactic reactions, which can be fatal. At the same time, there is no commercially available diagnostic kit in India to detect venom in a patient's blood, and the diagnosis is entirely symptomatic. The ICMR has called this syndromic approach a systemic flaw, since by the time symptoms appear, the venom may already have damaged tissue irreversibly. Together with scarce ICU beds, a lack of ventilator backups, inadequate training in managing anaphylaxis, and limited lab support for monitoring, this approach has offset the benefits of the availability of ASV.

India accounts for nearly half of all snakebites in the world, with agricultural workers and children being the worst affected. Kerala is home to over 100 snake species, including the Big Four venomous snakes: the common krait, Russell's viper, saw-scaled viper, and spectacled cobra. The State government has made snakebite a notifiable disease. It launched the 'SARPA' programme to professionalise snake rescue. The SARPA Padam and the upcoming SARPA Suraksha programmes also focus on assessing risk and conducting ward-level and school awareness campaigns. Progressive as the notification and 'SARPA' are relative to similar measures in the rest of India, the deaths are a sign that Kerala may be prevention-heavy and that it needs to reinforce the 'cure' as well. ASV is already widely available; the uncertainty that prevails over doctors' decision-making at the first point of contact needs to be mitigated. Many experts have also called for the development and use of rapid venom detection diagnostics to eliminate the risks of the syndromic approach. This must be followed by increasing hospital capacity and the availability of skilled medical workers to manage the consequences of that decision.

The *Chambers Dictionary* describes hubris as insolence, arrogance, and overconfidence that can lead to disaster or ruin. The moot question is whether this description fits the actions and personality of United States President Donald Trump. To many, if not most people, it would seem an apt description of the 47th President of the U.S. who, in his second term, seems intent on completing the unfinished tasks of his first, and in a manner that leaves no one in any doubt about his narcissistic attributes. To some, this may appear too harsh a judgment, but considering reactions from across the globe, the majority would agree.

Mr. Trump's actions at the beginning of this year in Venezuela, followed by his shenanigans in West Asia, suggest that he fully comprehends what he is doing. His supporters even cite historical precedents to justify his actions. They refuse to accept that all this only confirms the rise of the 'illiberal international', which is reshaping the global order today.

A false reading of victory

Wars usually tend to be fought in the belief that one side will come out victorious. In West Asia today, the situation conforms to the adage that not all wars need to have a winner. A 'no win fragile peace' in West Asia should ordinarily be a humbling experience for anyone, but Mr. Trump is intent on brandishing the claim that he has virtually eclipsed Iran. Higher levels of bombast cannot, however, obscure the reality that while Iran has suffered, it still stands tall though bruised. The Pakistan moderated truce talks in Islamabad have, meanwhile, provided a fig leaf for a truce of sorts and an opportunity to continue negotiations without either side having to prove its claims of victory.

Mr. Trump's folly of launching a war on a Friday/Saturday, hoping to force a result in his favour by Monday morning, has since been proven wrong. Spurred, perhaps, by his success in Venezuela, and driven by a delusion to win a Nobel Peace Prize by preventing another world war, Mr. Trump appears to see victory in every twist and turn of events in West Asia today. His occasional claims to peace having returned to the region appear increasingly hallucinating rather than real.

From Israel's point of view, a ceasefire on terms that have not achieved its objective of destroying Iran's war machine carries little meaning. That this should be so, even after the U.S. had joined the war on its side, would be even more hurtful, but it has little option but to go along. A major worry is that if the impression were to gain ground that, having launched a war



M.K. Narayanan

Former Director, Intelligence Bureau, a former National Security Adviser, and a former Governor of West Bengal

The West Asia conflict has exposed the disruptive leadership style of the United States President

to end all wars, it has now been reduced to being a nursemaid to a faltering peace, it would be highly damaging to its image and future.

As of now, there appear to be no victors or losers in a conflict 'manufactured' by Israel, and sustained by the U.S. If anything, suspicions have grown about Israel's role overall, as also about its manipulative skills, leading to a 'credibility gap' across the region. The role of the U.S. as a guarantor and guardian of many Arab States, including provision of a nuclear umbrella, also stands diminished. It is too early to assess how this would fundamentally alter power equations across the region.

Military leaders often declare deadlines to finish campaigns. Mr. Trump is, perhaps, the first civilian overlord to announce deadlines and determine victories, often randomly and without justification. This war has witnessed a series of announcements by Mr. Trump about the end of the war in West Asia as also several announcements of victory, leading to an 'Alice in Wonderland' scenario. Meanwhile, hundreds have lost their lives on account of an unnecessary conflict, and several thousand have been rendered homeless.

Modern war realities

One lesson to learn from the conflict – something that is less known and often overlooked – is how smaller armies can 'best' major powers by employing low cost effective weapons and tactics. Further, overestimating the strength of powerful allies – by Israel in respect of the U.S. – could prove a costly mistake. Iran might have been battered, but any belief that this would result in the dismantling of Iran's network of proxy militia, has clearly been belied. What has accompanied this is the deep suspicion – across the region, and also in the West and elsewhere – about Israel's Machiavellian tactics and policies of misinformation.

The failure of the Pakistan-mediated ceasefire talks held from early April in Islamabad raised the spectre of a fresh round of unbridled violence, with the U.S. President at one stage even threatening to erase Iran from the face of the earth. Yet, even as all bets were off on what to expect at the end of the two-week-long ceasefire, Mr. Trump pulled another rabbit out of his hat. As the world waited with concern at the grim prospect of a further escalation of a needless war, Mr. Trump announced that he was acceding to Pakistan's request and announced an indefinite extension of the ceasefire.

Mr. Trump's logic in acquiescing to Pakistan's request and endorsing the need to give Tehran's leadership more time to prepare a proper end to the war would have been praiseworthy, had it not

emanated from anyone other than the present incumbent of the White House, who is known for his mood swings. Notwithstanding the rickety ceasefire prospects, hopes have arisen that an all-out war has been avoided for now. Iran, however, is acting as a 'spoiler', seizing some ships in the Strait of Hormuz. There is also no clarity on the date or even the likelihood of the next round of U.S.-Iran talks.

The ceasefire does provide some breathing space for now. What is significant is the fact that a war initiated by Israel has since changed colour, with Israel's role becoming peripheral. The focus has shifted to the closure of the Strait of Hormuz, and on determining who has the authority to impose a blockade of international waters. In 1507, a Portuguese admiral took control over the Strait of Hormuz, turning it into a customs-controlled port that levied duties on passing trade. Mr. Trump is now exploiting this anachronism to turn it into a global chokepoint, imposing a naval blockade, and threatening the free flow of oil across the Strait. Given the unpredictability of his thought processes, nothing can be said as to how long the latest ceasefire would last, but his assertion that Tehran must never have a nuclear weapon, nor make or obtain one, would seem to suggest that the current ceasefire is likely at best to be a temporary one.

Pakistan's role

What is possibly most galling for India is the emergence of Pakistan as a conciliator – or to use Mr. Trump's phrase "an indispensable broker" as far as the conflict is concerned. Even as Mr. Trump seeks to garner all the glory, proclaiming that he has been able to stave-off the 10th major war of his times, Pakistan's role and its influence is witnessing an upswing. The turn of the wheel whereby Pakistan rather than India helped negotiate peace, is likely to make India unhappy, but this is the reality as of today. The special relationship between Field Marshal Asim Munir of Pakistan and the U.S. President is different from the usual cozying up of Pakistani generals with U.S. Presidents in the past, and this has helped shape Pakistan's emergence as a peacemaker that cannot be wished away. What should also not be lost sight of is that, of late, Pakistan has successfully managed to project itself as a net 'security guarantor' for the Islamic world. In the circumstances, India must tread lightly. It may be something that India had not bargained for, but any attempt at this time to denigrate Pakistan and Asim Munir's role could prove counterproductive. Patience has been India's sublime virtue, and this is the time for India to exercise it in full measure.

Summer as a source of income shock for gig workers

As India moves into another summer, early forecasts indicate intense heat ahead. Heatwaves are no longer rare; they are a recurring feature of Indian summers. The question is no longer whether extreme heat will return, but whether the country is prepared for its economic consequences.

Official data show that India did experience significant heat-related mortality in 2022. Meteorological trends indicate that heatwaves across large parts of the country have become more frequent and prolonged over the past decade. As policymakers review preparedness measures before peak summer arrives, there is one group which remains largely absent from the adaptation conversation – gig and delivery workers, whose livelihoods increasingly power India's urban economy.

From food delivery riders and e-commerce couriers to app-based drivers and logistics workers, millions now earn income through digital platforms. NITI Aayog estimates India had about 7.7 million gig workers in 2020-21, projected to reach over 23 million by 2029-30. As heatwaves intensify, this growing workforce will be among the most climate-exposed and least protected.

Heat cuts earnings

For gig and delivery workers, extreme heat is not just a matter of discomfort; it directly affects earnings. Income depends on the number of trips completed, orders delivered, or hours logged on an app. When temperatures surge, movement slows, fatigue increases, and health risks rise; yet, incentive structures remain unchanged.

Unlike salaried employees, gig workers cannot "work from home" or take paid leave during extreme heat. Logging off for a few hours means immediate income loss. Continuing to work through peak heat hours increases the risk of dehydration, heat exhaustion, and longer-term health stress. If the coming summer follows recent patterns, heat will be not just a public health concern but an income shock, forcing



Krishna Malakar

Assistant Professor in Climate Policy, IIT Madras

Resilience for gig workers means safe work and stable earnings during extreme heat

workers to choose between protecting their health and their earnings.

Preparedness remains incomplete

India has made progress in recognising heat as a public health risk. Heat Action Plans, early warning systems and emergency measures have improved preparedness in several cities. But most policies still treat heat as a medical emergency rather than an economic risk, assuming that people can adjust their behaviour. Advisories typically recommend staying indoors, reducing physical activity, and taking frequent breaks. But for gig and delivery workers, whose income depends on mobility, these options are not realistic.

Even where cities set up temporary drinking water kiosks, shaded rest areas, or cooling centres, these measures are rarely designed with highly mobile platform workers in mind. As a result, preparedness efforts may reduce mortality, but they do little to prevent income loss.

The weeks before peak summer offer a narrow but important policy window. Heat stress sits at the intersection of climate policy, labour regulation, urban planning and platform governance. Yet, responsibility remains fragmented.

Health departments focus on illness and mortality. Disaster management agencies focus on emergency response. Labour departments grapple with the ambiguous employment status of gig workers. Digital platforms optimise delivery times and incentives, with limited explicit integration of climate risk considerations. When accountability is distributed across institutions without coordination, heat risk for gig workers remains inadequately addressed. These vulnerabilities are further compounded for women gig workers, who often face additional health, safety and unpaid care burdens during extreme heat, making income disruption even harder to absorb.

If adaptation is to move beyond reactive

measures, this is the moment to expand its scope.

First, heat must be treated as a labour and productivity issue, not only a health one. Rest norms during peak heat hours, shaded congregation points, and access to drinking water at common waiting locations should be seen as basic safeguards.

Second, policymakers must acknowledge that extreme heat creates income volatility. Without mechanisms – whether through labour protections or better integration with existing welfare systems – to cushion these losses, adaptation will remain incomplete.

Third, digital labour platforms need to be part of the preparedness conversation. Heat-responsive design such as moderating delivery pressure during peak heat hours or introducing more flexible performance metrics – can lower exposure without halting services.

Finally, stronger institutional coordination is needed before summer intensifies. Collaboration among labour departments, urban local bodies, disaster management authorities, and platform regulators would signal that heat risk is being treated as an economic issue, not just a seasonal emergency.

Rethinking resilience

India's cities increasingly depend on gig and delivery workers to function. Food, medicines and essential goods move through urban systems because this workforce absorbs daily risks. As temperatures rise, those risks will intensify.

Climate resilience cannot be measured only by advisories issued or cooling centres opened. For gig workers navigating city streets on two-wheelers and bicycles, resilience means the ability to work safely – and to earn without enduring silent income losses during extreme heat.

If heat preparedness continues to overlook gig and delivery workers, the country will enter another season of rising temperatures without protecting one of its most visible and essential workforces.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

AAP defections

The exodus of high-profile leaders from the primary membership of the Aam Aadmi Party is the party's worst existential crisis to date, leaving it at a political crossroads. For a party that set out to overhaul the political system, the steady loss of leaders is a clear sign of inadequate engagement by its central leadership with the rank and file. AAP

needs to strengthen its grassroots, purge power brokers and sycophants, and quell internal dissent and factionalism by grooming second-rung leaders through a spirit of consensus.

B. Suresh Kumar,
Coimbatore

The ease with which the MPs crossed over from a party avowedly founded on

lofty ideals to a party espousing the Hindutva ideology was astonishing. Are we to deduce that little ideology divides politicians in India? The mask of idealism has fallen off the faces of the defectors. There seems to be some substance in the allegation that the MPs joined the BJP to get "dry-cleaned".

G. David Milton,
Maruthancode, Tamil Nadu

Tamil Nadu results

Most pre/post poll predictions have indicated that the ruling DMK will come back to power in Tamil Nadu, if not with a massive mandate but with a comfortable majority. However, the fair, impartial and flawless declaration of the results depends on how the Election Commission of India which has proved beyond doubt that it is

blatantly partisan in favour of the BJP government and its allies, is going to conduct itself during the counting and declaration of the final results.

It is unfortunate that the Election Commission has become the most controversial conductor of fair and free elections in India.

Tharcius S. Fernando,
Chennai

Stunning show

What a thrilling afternoon at Chepauk. Despite CSK's fighting 158/7, Gujarat Titans were simply unstoppable. It was a clinical, dominant performance worthy of champions.

S.M. Jeeva,
Chennai

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.

Kerala's heat-ridden woes

NCSC seeks report on Mamata's 'derogatory' remark

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

The National Commission for Scheduled Castes (NCSC) on Sunday took *suo motu* cognisance of a video clip showing West Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee allegedly using “derogatory” language against the SC community during an election rally.

The NCSC has written to the Chief Secretary of West Bengal and the Director-General of Police, directing them to submit a detailed report within three days.

The Commission referred to a video that appeared on “Kolkata TV” on April 26, regarding Ms. Banerjee’s alleged remarks made during a rally in Kolkata’s Chowringhee area recently while campaigning for a Trinamool candidate during the ongoing Assembly polls in the State.

“Suo-motu cognisance has been taken by the National Commission for Scheduled Castes on a video that appeared in ‘Kolkata TV’ wherein derogatory language has been used by Mamata Banerjee, Chief Minister of West Bengal, against SC community,” the notice stated.

“The Commission has decided to investigate/inquire into the matter in pursuance of the powers conferred upon it under Article 338 of the Constitution. You are hereby requested to submit an action taken report to the undersigned within 3 days,” it said. NCSC Chairman Kishor Makwana said the Commission is committed to safeguarding the constitutional rights of Scheduled Castes.

For two women, a fight for justice in poll contest

BJP's Ratna Debnath, and Left Front's Sabina Yasmin, whose daughter died in post-poll violence in Nadia, have turned personal loss into questions of safety, governance, and State accountability

Shrabana Chatterjee
KOLKATA

Two mothers from different corners of West Bengal and contrasting social backgrounds are contesting the Assembly elections with one aim: to bring justice to their daughters, who were killed in separate, gruesome incidents in the State.

Ratna Debnath, from the Panihati Assembly constituency in North 24 Parganas, has emerged as a key face of the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP)'s campaign. For Ms. Debnath, whose daughter – a doctor – was raped and murdered at Kolkata's R.G. Kar Hospital and Medical College in August 2024, the election is a personal quest for justice for her daughter.

PM's assurance

A few days ago, when she shared the stage with Prime Minister Narendra Modi in Panihati, she spoke about her daughter. “I want to make her name public,” she said, prompting Mr. Modi to assure her that files relating to the case would be reopened after the polls.

Away from the media gaze, another mother is on a similar quest. Sabina Yasmin, whose nine-year-old daughter Tamanna Khatun died when crude bombs were hurled following the bypoll results in Nadia district's Kaliganj in July 2025, is the Left Front candidate from the seat.

She is fighting the election to ensure that her daughter's death due to



Campaign trail: BJP's Ratna Debnath during an election rally at Panihati in North 24 Parganas of West Bengal; (right) CPI(M) candidate Sabina Yasmin interacts with people during a campaign in Nadia. PTI



political violence is accounted for.

‘Our fight is the same’

“Our fight is the same. She is fighting for her daughter's justice, and so am I. The parties may be different, the politics may be different, but our fight is the same,” Ms. Yasmin said of Ms. Debnath's candidature.

Though the two women are from opposing ends of the political spectrum, both aggrieved mothers have blamed the ruling Trinamool Congress and Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee for their daughters' deaths.

The deaths under different circumstances have raised questions about the role of the ruling establishment.

Tamanna Khatun was killed inside her home when bombs were allegedly hurled during victory processions organised by

the Trinamool Congress workers in Kaliganj, raising concerns about the culture of political violence in the State.

The rape and murder of the young doctor at R.G. Kar Hospital by a former civic police volunteer in August 2024 became a watershed moment in West Bengal politics.

Widespread outrage, mourning and protest were witnessed for months.

The incident was the biggest challenge that the Mamata Banerjee-led government had to deal with in its third term.

Pursuit of justice

“My first priority will be to ensure justice for my daughter and not let any other ‘Abhaya’ happen in this State,” Ms. Debnath has repeatedly said in her campaigns.

Ms. Debnath is contesting against the CPI(M)'s Ka-

latan Dasgupta, a key face of protests in the R.G. Kar incident, and Trinamool's Tirthankar Ghosh, son of Nirmal Ghosh, MLA, who was questioned by the Central Bureau of Investigation for allegedly tampering with evidence of the crime.

On the other hand, Ms. Yasmin is contesting against the BJP's Bapan Ghosh and Trinamool Congress candidate Alifa Ahmed, whose by-election victory in June 2025 and the subsequent celebratory processions were linked to the death of her minor daughter.

For both women, the electoral battle is deeply personal, shaped by grief and a search for justice. Their stepping into the political arena has transformed their individual tragedies into broader questions of safety, governance, and State accountability.

Mamata seeks Bhabanipur support, PM reaches out to Matuas in campaign last leg

Shiv Sahay Singh
KOLKATA

With hours left for campaigning in the last phase of election in West Bengal, Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Sunday focused on issues concerning the Matua population, and said the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) would ensure citizenship to the community of Hindu refugees that has migrated from Bangladesh.

Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee focused on her constituency in Bhabanipur, where she held a roadshow. She raised several issues, including the deletions of under-adjudicated voters from the electoral roll, and targeted the administration that has been appointed by the Election Commission. “Those who are arresting now must think about getting arrested in future. Sin spares no one,” she said.

Mr. Modi held a public meeting at Thakurnagar in North 24 Parganas, and said the Trinamool Congress openly opposed the Citizenship (Amendment) Act. “Don't fall for the TMC's lies on CAA. All refugees will receive permanent address in this country... If someone votes for Trinamool, they will be making their ancestors sad,” he said.

The Prime Minister, who offered prayers at the Matua temple in Thakurnagar, recalled his visit to Orakandi in Bangladesh ahead of the 2021 Assembly polls in West Bengal. The Matua sect of Namasudra Hindus originated from Orakandi in the 19th century and its followers have



Prime Minister Narendra Modi being felicitated during a 'Vijay Sankalp' rally in Arambagh, West Bengal. PTI

been migrating to Bengal.

“I pledge before the brothers and sisters of the Matua Namasudra community members that they will receive citizenship through the Citizenship (Amendment) Act. They will be provided the same documents which other citizens of this country have,” he said.

The Special Intensive Revision of electoral rolls has resulted in a significant number of voter deletions in the Matua community, resulting in uncertainty among them. The community has largely voted for the BJP in the past. Dozens of Assembly seats in North 24 Parganas and Nadia are dominated by the community, and its support will be crucial in determining the electoral fortune of the party.

Mr. Modi, who held another rally at Haripal in Hooghly, and a roadshow in north Kolkata, also touched on the issue of women's safety. Accusing the Trinamool of “sheltering goons who torture women”, he said the BJP has given ticket to Sandeshkha-

li's Rekha Patra and the mother of the R.G. Kar victim, Ratna Debnath, and this proves the party's commitment to ensuring women's security.

In Bhabanipur, Ms. Banerjee began her campaign with a roadshow in Chakraberia and addressed four public meetings. The Trinamool chairperson, who is up against the BJP's Suwendu Adhikari, walked for over 80 minutes from Chakraberia intersection to Hazra Fire Brigade and her procession went through several lanes and by-lanes.

Ms. Banerjee tried to assure the electorate that it has not faced any issues over the past 15 years that she has been in power. “I scored a century in the first round, I will do it again in the second round. BJP is scared. That's why they brought in the central forces. All the OCs (officers in-charge of police stations) have been changed. They (BJP) are indulging in hooliganism. Cast your own vote. Keep a copy of the voter slip so that NRC cannot be implemented,” she said.

Drug menace emerges as key plank in Amit Shah's campaign for Punjab polls

Nistula Hebbar
Vikas Vasudeva
NEW DELHI/CHANDIGARH

Scarcely would the campaign trail for the West Bengal election grow cold when Union Home Minister Amit Shah directs his attention to Punjab, with a visit scheduled for next month, targeting the drug menace in the State, which shares an International Border with Pakistan.

The Assembly election in Punjab is due next year and the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), by bringing seven Rajya Sabha members from the ruling Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) in the State over to its side, has signalled that the battle has commenced.

Top sources in the BJP have told *The Hindu* that Mr. Shah will be visiting the State as often as once a month, throughout the year, covering each district.

A crackdown on the drug trade in the State will be a part of this. After the near disappearance of violent Left Wing Extremism in the country, the war against drugs is not just a political but a policy imperative for the Centre, said a source.

‘No alliance with SAD’

BJP president Nitin Nabin, in a recent TV interview, has already announced that the party would be going alone in the Punjab polls, with no revival of its oldest alliance, with the Shiromani Akali Dal (SAD)



Poll bugle: Union Home Minister Amit Shah during a rally at Moga in Punjab on March 14. ANI

on the anvil.

Over the years, the drug menace has remained a politically and socially significant issue in Punjab. In March, Mr. Shah, who sounded the party's poll bugle at the “*Badlav* rally” in Moga, sought a chance to form the next government, promising that “the BJP will free Punjab from the scourge of drugs within two years”.

Plans to contest solo

Pointing out that the BJP used to contest elections as a “younger brother” earlier, therefore its government could not be formed, Mr. Shah stated that in the 2027 Assembly election, the party will fight to form its own government in Punjab. The BJP and the SAD had been alliance partners since 1996 and had long contested Assembly elections together under a seat-sharing arrangement, with the SAD fielding candidates for 94 seats and the BJP for 23.

The BJP contested these

electoral battles as a “junior partner” in the alliance, which many in the party's State unit believed restricted the BJP's growth beyond urban centres for years.

However, after the SAD chose to sever ties with the National Democratic Alliance (NDA) over the contentious Central farm laws in 2020, the BJP has been pushing for its expansion across the State to achieve its solo ambitions.

While Punjab presents a distinct political landscape where religion, region and caste-based coalitions remain central to the State's electoral arithmetic, it appears that the BJP is placing the drug menace at the centre of its campaign strategy. “Unlike caste or religious identity, the drug crisis cuts across communal and regional lines and a sustained focus on its eradication could help the BJP build broader electoral appeal among sections of society,” said a senior party leader.

BJP attacking Bengali culture, pride: Kejriwal; Modi won't have his way in Bengal: Tejashwi

The Hindu Bureau
KOLKATA

Former Delhi Chief Minister and Aam Aadmi Party convener Arvind Kejriwal on Sunday joined the Trinamool Congress campaign in West Bengal, addressing three election rallies – two in Kolkata and one in Howrah.

His visit comes during the last leg of poll campaign in the State. Campaigning for the second phase of the Assembly elections will conclude at 6 p.m. on Monday. A few days ago, the AAP suffered a major setback when seven of its 10 MPs crossed over to the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP).

Speaking at a public meeting in Belehghata in support of Trinamool candidate Kunal Ghosh, Mr.



Arvind Kejriwal during a public meeting in support of Trinamool candidate Kunal Ghosh at Belehghata in Kolkata on Sunday. ANI

Kejriwal accused the BJP of deploying “all the Army and central forces” in the State as if “the people here are all terrorists”. “This is an attack on Bengal, on Bengali culture and pride. You will have to reply to this,” he said.

Mr. Kejriwal described the West Bengal Assembly

election as a fight to save “the democracy” in the country and praised Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee, while urging people to vote for the Trinamool. He alleged that the BJP had “captured” Delhi by framing him in false corruption cases, though courts had found him innocent.

Tejashwi lauds Mamata

Along with Mr. Kejriwal, Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD) leader and former Deputy Chief Minister of Bihar Tejashwi Yadav also campaigned for the Trinamool. Speaking at a public rally at Jorasanko in Kolkata, Mr. Yadav said Ms. Banerjee was “fighting like a tigress”.

“The Prime Minister,

the Home Minister, all BJP Chief Ministers, the ED, the CBI and also ‘godi media’ (partisan media) are all against Mamata *Didi*, but she is fighting like a tigress, and Modiji will not have his way in West Bengal,” the RJD leader said.

While Mr. Kejriwal and Mr. Yadav are campaigning in the State in support of the Trinamool Congress, Congress leader Rahul Gandhi has launched scathing attacks on the State government and Ms. Banerjee.

Mr. Gandhi, who has held multiple public rallies, accused the Trinamool Congress leadership of paving the way for the BJP in West Bengal. On Saturday, Mr. Gandhi accused both the BJP and the Trinamool of corruption and misuse.

Trinamool running a reign of terror in West Bengal, says Rahul Gandhi

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Ahead of the final phase of polling for the West Bengal Assembly election, senior Congress leader Rahul Gandhi on Sunday accused the ruling Trinamool Congress of running a reign of terror in the State.

“In West Bengal today, it is not democracy but TMC's reign of terror that prevails. Intimidating, attacking, and eliminating



opposing voices after votes are cast – this has become the defining character of TMC,” Mr. Gandhi wrote in a social media post flagging

the murder of a Congress worker. Debdeep Chatterjee, a share trader, was beaten to death allegedly by a mob in Asansol on Saturday after an argument broke out when his car brushed against a parked motorbike near his home.

The Congress's West Bengal unit, in a post on X, said that Mr. Chatterjee worked closely with Asansol North Congress candidate Prasenjit Puitandi. It further said that the “vic-

tim was attacked and beaten by miscreants” linked to the ruling Trinamool and died of his injuries shortly thereafter.

Quoting this post Mr. Gandhi, extended his deepest condolences to the grieving family and called the murder by “TMC-affiliated goons” as “utterly reprehensible”.

He said the Congress's politics has never been based on violence, nor will it ever be.

Trinamool files case over 'misuse of National Flag'

Press Trust of India
KOLKATA

The Trinamool Congress on Sunday lodged a complaint against BJP candidate Papia Adhikari, alleging misuse of the National Flag during election campaign in the Tollygunge Assembly constituency in south Kolkata.

The complaint was filed by Trinamool leader Kohinoor Mazumdar.

ASKUS

Vaishali R Venkat

Q I have invested in a small-cap fund (Direct plan-growth) through SIP for quite some time, but it's highly volatile. Now, I want to invest in a more stable fund, such as a multi-cap or a flexi-cap fund. I want to switch to another fund and also minimise my tax liabilities. Is it possible to switch from one fund to another?

NARINDER GAUTAM

A First of all, thank you for showing interest in *The Hindu Moneywise*. The word 'stable' in markets can be tricky. Even flexi-cap and multi-cap funds are not always stable and can witness volatility and declines at times. If stability is your priority, stocks and mutual funds may not be suitable, as they are inherently volatile and are better suited for long-term investing, say five to seven years at least. For short-term, you can park your funds in instruments such as FDs, RDs, or certain debt funds. With regard to switching funds, even within the same fund house, it is treated as a redemption (selling of units). If you exit with a profit, capital gains tax will apply, depending on the holding period of your units. If you exit at a loss, it erodes your capital, though such losses can be set off against gains for tax purposes. In both cases, you also need the discipline to reinvest the lump sum into another fund, without spending it upfront. A simpler approach could be to pause or cancel your future SIP instalments, while retaining the accumulated units/amount without redeeming. Further, you can redirect the future SIP contributions into a new fund of your choice. This approach offers several advantages. It works by separating your past SIP accumulations from your future investment decisions. Since you are not redeeming your existing units, there is no sale taking place, and therefore no immediate capital gains tax arises. Likewise, if the fund is currently at a loss, you also avoid booking a loss by staying invested. In effect, your existing corpus stays invested and it gets an opportunity to regain value over time. Additionally, since there is no redemption, you also bypass the exit load (if applicable) that is typically charged when units are redeemed within a short holding period, especially under one year. Above all, as per your wish, you also get an opportunity to redirect your future monthly contributions into a fund of your choice. Another behavioural advantage: since you are not redeeming and receiving a lump sum in your bank account, you reduce the risk of spending the money impulsively. This approach creates a balanced strategy where you minimise taxes and costs, avoid premature loss realisation, and gradually improve the quality of your portfolio through future investments.

Q Sir, I am a senior citizen with total taxable income below the taxable threshold. Currently, banks and other financial institutions deduct TDS on the interest from my deposits. So, can I submit Form 15H to banks and institutions from April 2026 to avoid TDS and claim a refund later?

M. VIJAYARAGHAVAN

A Sir, from April 1, 2026, both the Forms 15G & 15H were replaced by a new unified Form No. 121. From this financial year onwards, all eligible taxpayers, both below and above 60 years of age, will only have to submit Form No. 121, and the earlier Forms are no longer valid. Form 121 applies to income such as PF withdrawals, pension, rental income, interest on deposits, insurance commission, income from mutual funds, dividends, and proceeds from life insurance policies. HUFs are eligible to use this form, whereas companies, firms, and non-residents are not. Please note that Form 121 must be submitted separately to each bank or financial institution from which you earn interest income. *(The writer is an NISM & CRISIL-certified Wealth Manager and certified in NISM's Research Analyst module)*

Send queries on personal finance and investing to the moneywise@thehindu.co.in ID. Our experts in personal finance will respond to select queries, but will not give specific recommendations for investment in a particular mutual fund, share or fixed deposit.



ILLUSTRATION: SAAI

Rupee depreciation and its impact on investments

The correction we are witnessing in the equity market is due to multiple reasons and rupee depreciation is just one of them; this is not something under your control and to worry about

CURRENCY CAULDRON

Joydeep Sen

In the recent past, there has been lot of apprehensions on the weakening of our currency, and rightly so. For a perspective on the extent of weakening of INR, over the past few decades, it depreciates on an average 2.5% to 3% per year against the U.S. Dollar. We as a growing economy import a lot, higher than our exports, and to manage this, our currency depreciates. The issue in the recent past has been that in 2025-26, INR moved from 85.53 to the green-back on March 31, 2025 to 92.76 on March 30, 2026 i.e. a depreciation of 8.45%. If we look at the intermediate low point of 94.71 on March 23, 2026, till that point of time, our currency had depreciated 10.73%. How does this impact you?

Equity investments

The exchange rate does not have much of a direct impact on the equity market, as long as you are investing in India. Currency depreciation does have a negative impact on sentiments in the market, but the market is the confluence of 'n' number of factors, and we see the movement as the cumulative effect. The correction we are witnessing in the equity market is due to multiple reasons e.g. selling by foreign portfolio investors



High inflation is a negative for both equity and bond markets, but more so for the bond market as inflation is a bigger variable for interest rates

(FPIs), crude oil price flaring up, etc., and rupee depreciation is just one of those reasons. This is not something under your control and you need not worry much about this.

Debt investments

Weaker currency leads to something called imported inflation. As an example, when we import crude oil, there is a certain price in U.S. dollars. That gets converted to our currency at the prevailing exchange rate. Weaker the currency, higher is the landed price. This adds to our inflation. High inflation is a negative for both equity and bond markets, but more so for the bond market as inflation is a bigger variable for interest rates. A weak INR would contribute to imported inflation going forward. The RBI, in the policy review on April 8, 2026, projected consumer price inflation at 4.6% in 2026-27. For this projection, the RBI assumed normal monsoon (which is a question mark now), crude oil price at \$85/ barrel (lower than current prevailing price) and INR at 94 (weaker than current level). That is to



Allocation to gold should be say 10% of your portfolio, or maximum 15%. The rationale is, gold is not a mainstream investment like equity or bonds

say, currency weakness has already been factored in, for projecting inflation at 4.6%. Going forward, if currency does not depreciate significantly from current level, it should not be a major concern for your investments. We discussed so far, the adverse impact of rupee depreciation on your portfolio. There are two investment avenues that benefit from this. One is gold. There is an international price of gold denominated in U.S. dollars. This gets converted to rupees at the prevailing exchange rate. Weaker the rupee, higher is the INR price of gold. History shows that the returns gold has given us, over the decades, while the major part is gold price movement per se (in USD), a substantial chunk is due to weakening of our currency. The learning is, you should have some allocation to gold in your portfolio. Having said that, allocation to gold should be say 10% of your portfolio, or maximum 15%. The rationale is, gold is not a mainstream investment like equity or bonds. The other investment

that benefits from currency weakness is global investments. When you invest in stocks or bonds or funds in USA (or any other country), it gets converted from INR to USD (or any other currency). When you redeem your investments, it gets converted back to INR. During the investment period, if rupee depreciates (which it usually does), you get that benefit as well. You can invest abroad though relevant Mutual Fund products available in India. You can invest directly in stocks or bonds or other avenues abroad, which would be part of the Liberalized Remittance Scheme (LRS) limit. Outbound products available at GIFT City are part of the LRS limit.

Expenses

Your expenses in India are impacted due to inflation i.e. purchasing power of rupee comes down progressively. Even if part of this inflation is due to currency weakening, it is not under your control, and you cannot do much about it. Rather, if it is about your expenses abroad, in USA or any other country, then there is something you can do. Apart from expenses, you can look at investing abroad as part of portfolio allocation and get the benefit of diversification. If and when expenses crop up, which you are envisaging now, you can redeem to the extent required, otherwise let it continue. *(Joydeep Sen is a corporate trainer (financial markets) and author)*

Arriving at terminal wealth

THINKINVESTOR

Terminal wealth, which is the amount you need at the end of the time horizon for a goal, should be enough to fund the goal after paying taxes. But accounting for taxes is easier said than done

Venkatesh Bangaruswamy

The amount you need at the end of the time horizon for a goal is referred to as terminal wealth. In this article, we discuss how to determine the terminal wealth for a goal. We also look at how to adjust for taxes on goal-based investments, as taxes can impact a goal's terminal wealth.

Tax drag

Suppose you want to provide for your child's college education ten years hence. As the first step, you must find out the current cost of college education for a branch of study you believe your child will pursue. For other goals such as buying a house, you must consider the current cost of buying your desired house. Next, you must consider the inflation related to the goal. A search on the Internet suggests that education inflation is 10%. Suppose the education you want your child to have costs ₹25 lakh today. You must determine how much it would cost 10 years hence at 10% inflation. That would be the terminal wealth required for the life goal.

The above calculation is simple but ignores the effect of taxes on the terminal wealth.

The terminal wealth should be enough to fund the goal after paying taxes. But accounting for taxes is easier said than done. This is because of two reasons. One, it is typical for individuals to invest in bank deposits for their bond allocation. The interest income on deposits is taxed annually on an accrual basis.

And two, you must rebalance your portfolio starting five years from the end of the time horizon for the goal. This means you could incur long term capital gains tax on your equity investments in the years you rebalance. The impact of taxes on your portfolio returns is referred to as the tax drag.

Conclusion

You can adjust for the tax drag by projecting the proportion of equity and bonds in the portfolio through the time horizon for a goal considering your rebalancing process. Then, you must adjust the portfolio value each year for taxes. But all this defeats the objective of keeping your investment process simple. An easier approach is to add, say, 10-15% to the pre-tax terminal wealth as buffer for taxes. Alternatively, you could decide that any shortfall in terminal wealth because of tax drag can be made good with surplus cash or from additional borrowings taken at the end of the time horizon for a life goal. *(The author offers training programmes for individuals to manage their personal investments)*

Personal Loans

Rates and Charges		Loan amount 5 lakh Tenure 1 year	Loan amount 5 lakh Tenure 1 year	(% of loan amount)
Name of Lender	Interest Rate (%)	EMI (Rs)	EMI (Rs)	Processing fee
HDFC Bank	10.50-21.00	10,747-13,527	2,149-2,705	Upto 2.5% (Maximum Rs 25,000)
Citi Bank	9.99-16.49	10,621-12,290	2,124-2,458	Upto 3%
Tata Capital	10.99 onwards	10,869 onwards	2,174 onwards	Upto 2.75%
ICICI Bank	10.50-19.00	10,747-12,970	2,149-2,594	Upto 2.50%
Bank of Baroda	10.00-15.60	10,624-12,053	2,125-2,411	Rs 1,000-10,000
State Bank of India	9.60-13.85	10,525-11,595	2,105-2,319	Upto 1.5% (Maximum Rs 15,000)
Axis Bank	12.00-21.00	11,122-13,527	2,224-2,705	1.5%-2%
Kotak Mahindra Bank	10.75-24.00*	10,809-14,384	2,162-2,877	Upto 2.5%
Bank of India	9.35-12.35	10,464-11,211	2,093-2,242	Upto 2% (Maximum Rs 10,000)
Canara Bank	10.20-13.90	10,673-11,608	2,135-2,322	Upto 0.5%
Punjab National Bank^	8.95-14.50	10,367-11,764	2,073-2,353	Upto 1%
HSBC Bank	9.75-15.00	10,562-11,895	2,112-2,379	Upto 1%
Federal Bank	10.49-17.99	10,744-12,694	2,149-2,539	Upto 3%
Union Bank of India	8.90-13.00	10,355-11,677	2,071-2,275	Upto 0.5% (Maximum Rs 7,500)
Bajaj Finserv	13.00 onwards	11,377 onwards	2,275 onwards	Upto 4%
Punjab & Sind Bank	9.50-11.50	10,501-10,996	2,100-2,199	Upto 1%
South Indian Bank	10.15-14.45	10,660-11,751	2,132-2,350	2%
IDBI Bank	9.50-14.00	10,501-11,634	2,100-2,327	1% (Minimum Rs 2,500)
UCO Bank	10.05-10.45	10,636-10,735	2,127-2,147	Upto 1%
IDFC First Bank	10.49 onwards	10,809 onwards	2,162 onwards	Upto 3.50%
Bank of Maharashtra	9.55-12.90**	10,513-11,351	2,103-2,270	Upto 1%
Indian Overseas Bank	12.05	11,135	2,227	Upto 0.75%
Indian Bank	9.05-13.65	10,391-11,544	2,078-2,309	1%**
Dhanlaxmi Bank	11.90-15.70	11,097-12,079	2,219-2,416	Upto 2.5% (Minimum Rs 1,250)
IndusInd Bank	11.00 onwards	10,871 onwards	2,174 onwards	2.5% onwards

*For pensioners, NIL processing fees for loan upto Rs 25,000, and fees of Rs 250 for loan above Rs 25,000.

Car Loans

Rates and Charges		Loan amount 5 lakh Tenure 1 year	(% of loan amount)
Name of Lender	Interest Rate (%)	EMI (Rs)	Processing fee
Union Bank of India	8.20-9.40	10,186-10,477	Up to Rs. 1,000
Punjab National Bank	8.05-8.90	10,150-10,355	NIL upto 30th September 2022
Bank of Baroda	7.95-11.25	10,126-10,934	0.50% (Rs 2,500-Rs 10,000)
Canara Bank	8.30-11.00	10,210-10,871	0.25% (Rs 1,000-5,000)
Bank of India	8.25-9.95	10,198-10,611	NIL
UCO Bank	8.05	10,150	1% (Upto Rs 1,500)
State Bank of India	7.80-8.65	10,090-10,294	NIL
IDBI Bank	8.60 - 9.90	10,282-10,599	Rs 2,500
Bank of Maharashtra*	8.20-11.70	10,186-11,047	NIL
Indian Overseas Bank	8.95	10,367	0.5% - 0.6% (Rs 500-Rs 10,000)
ICICI Bank	8.10 onwards	10,162 onwards	Rs 5,500-Rs 8,500
HDFC Bank	8.35 onwards	10,222 onwards	0.5% (Rs 3,500-Rs 8,000)
Karnataka Bank	8.61-10.66	10,283-10,787	0.5% (Rs 2,500-Rs 10,000)
Federal Bank	9.90	10,599	Rs 2,000 - Rs 4,500
Axis Bank	8.20-11.40	10,186-10,971	Rs 3,500-Rs 5,500
South Indian Bank	10.55-12.00	10,759-11,122	1% (Max: Rs. 10,000)
City Union Bank	13.00-13.50	11,377-11,505	1% (Min: Rs 250)

**0.25% interest rate concession for existing housing loan borrowers and corporate salary account holder. 0.05% concession on interest rate to women & armed forces personnel subject to minimum floor ceiling of RLLR.

Rates and charges as on February 15

Source: Paisabazaar.com

BELFAST

N. Ireland police suspect dissident republicans in latest car bombing



▲ Northern Ireland police said on Sunday they suspect dissident republicans could be behind an overnight car bomb attack outside a police station near Belfast. Politicians denounced the incident, with First Minister Michelle O'Neill from the pro-Irish Sinn Fein party saying those behind the attack "speak for absolutely no one". AFP

JOHANNESBURG

Taiwan Minister hits out at China, says island will not bow to pressure



▲ Taiwan's Foreign Minister Lin Chia-lung on a visit to Eswatini slammed China's move to pressure African nations into revoking travel permits, saying it will not "bow its head." Taiwan's President postponed a trip to Eswatini last week after "Seychelles, Mauritius, Madagascar revoked the charter's overflight permits". AFP

DAMASCUS

Syrian court begins first public trial of ousted leader Assad and allies



▲ A Syrian court conducted the first hearing on Sunday in the trial of ousted ruler Bashar al-Assad and senior figures from his government. Mr. Assad and his brother Maher have fled Syria and will be tried in absentia, but one of their relatives, former security official Atef Najib, was present in the courtroom. AFP

BOGOTA

Explosive device kills 20 on bus in Colombia amid rising violence



▲ An explosive device killed 20 people travelling on a bus in southwestern Colombia on Saturday, an attack the country's Army chief described as a "terrorist act" that also left at least 30 injured as violence linked to drug trafficking escalates. At least 26 incidents have taken place in the past two days in the southwest region. AP

Israel and Hezbollah call out Lebanon truce breach

Agence France-Presse
JERUSALEM

Israel and Hezbollah traded blame over violations of the fragile ceasefire in Lebanon on Sunday, with Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu saying the military was "vigorously" targeting the Iran-backed group as both sides claimed new attacks.

The accusations came as the foes said they carried out fresh attacks in southern Lebanon.

"Hezbollah's violations are, in practice, dismantling the ceasefire," Mr. Netanyahu said. Under the terms of the truce, which was recently extended, Israel says it has the right to respond to planned, imminent or ongoing attacks.

Hezbollah said its fighters targeted Israeli troops in response to their ceasefire violations. "The enemy's continued ceasefire violations... and above all its continued occupation of Lebanese territory will be met with a response and a resistance," it said in a statement.

Araghchi heads to Russia after diplomatic push in Pakistan

Iran's top diplomat made a second visit to Islamabad as it works to save negotiations with the U.S.; departs for Moscow to meet Putin; Trump says Tehran can contact the U.S. if it wants to negotiate

Agence France-Presse
ISLAMABAD

Iran's Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi returned to Islamabad on Sunday, ping-ponging from capital to capital as mediators hoped to keep peace talks between Tehran and the United States alive.

Mr. Araghchi visited Oman's Muscat on Saturday after leaving Pakistan, and left Moscow after his second visit to the Pakistani capital to meet Russian President Vladimir Putin, but there remained no indication that direct U.S.-Iranian talks would resume.

On Saturday, U.S. President Donald Trump scotched a planned trip to Islamabad by his negotiators Steve Witkoff and Jared Kushner.

But in a sign that indirect efforts were ongoing, the Fars news agency reported that Iran had transmitted "written messages"



Pakistan's Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif (left) meets Iran's Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi during the latter's first visit on April 25. AFP

to the Americans via Pakistan that were "about some of the red lines of the Islamic Republic of Iran, including nuclear issues and the Strait of Hormuz".

Those messages were not, however, part of any negotiations, Fars said.

There had been hopes for a new round of talks on Saturday, with Mr. Witkoff and Mr. Kushner due to visit Islamabad, but Mr. Trump later told Fox News he had scrapped the trip, saying there was no point

up by Iran's closure of the Strait of Hormuz and mid-term elections scheduled for November.

Mr. Araghchi described his initial Pakistan trip as "very fruitful" but signalled scepticism over Washington's intentions, saying he had "yet to see if the U.S. is truly serious about diplomacy".

With the Minister bound for Russia, Iran's ISNA news agency quoted Tehran's Ambassador Kazem Jalali as saying: "The Foreign Minister will meet with Russian President Vladimir Putin on Monday", adding that Mr. Araghchi would "consult Russian officials regarding the latest status of the negotiations, ceasefire, and surrounding developments".

Russia's Foreign Ministry confirmed on Sunday that Mr. Araghchi would travel to Moscow "with the aim of holding talks", the RIA Novosti news agency reported, without specifying with whom.

Sri Lanka seeks investors for loss-making Mattala airport built with loans from China

Meera Srinivasan
COLOMBO

Sri Lanka has called for Expressions of Interest to run its loss-making international airport in Mattala, in the southern Hambantota district, with a Cabinet-appointed committee tasked with negotiating the deal with prospective domestic and foreign investors.

The Ministry of Ports and Civil Aviation, on behalf of Airport and Aviation Services, "invites proposals from prospective investors i.e. Companies, Corporations, Firms, and Joint Ventures" for investments to "utilise resources" of the Mattala Rajapaksa International Airport (MRIA), according to an official statement.

The EOI, which includes airside, aerodrome and landside operations, is open to both domestic and international entities, the statement said.

Indo-Russian deal

India has in the past expressed interest to operate



A view of the Mattala Rajapaksa International Airport. The facility is yet to prove commercially viable since its launch in 2013. AFP

The airport has accumulated a net loss of nearly \$130 million, according to the Auditor General

the airport in Mattala, which has made headlines as the 'world's emptiest airport', including through a joint venture with a Russian company. However, the proposals did not take off.

The Mattala airport was developed with a nearly \$200-million Chinese loan by former President Ma-

hinda Rajapaksa, who sought to develop his stronghold, along with other big ticket infrastructure projects such as the Hambantota port, also backed by the Chinese. However, the airport facility is yet to prove commercially viable since its launch in 2013.

It has recorded a cumulative loss amounting to nearly LKR 40 billion (roughly \$130 million), the Auditor General's report said in 2024.

The airport currently has no scheduled flights but handles charter planes, officials said.

Ukraine marks Chernobyl anniversary amid Russia war

Agence France-Presse
KYIV

Ukraine President Volodymyr Zelenskyy accused Russia of "nuclear terrorism" on Sunday, as Ukraine marked the 40th anniversary of the Chernobyl nuclear disaster amid deadly new drone attacks.

Five people were killed across Ukraine after Moscow launched more than 100 drones overnight, the latest in an almost nightly barrage the country has faced since the beginning of the war in 2022.

In a social media post marking the Chernobyl anniversary, Mr. Zelenskyy said Russia's invasion was "again bringing the world to the brink of a man-made



Volodymyr Zelenskyy

disaster". He highlighted how Russian drones regularly pass over Chernobyl and that one had hit its protective shell last year.

Any repairs to the massive metal outer structure are virtually impossible due to Russia's invasion, according to the environment group Greenpeace.

"The world must not allow this nuclear terrorism to continue, and the best way is to force Russia to stop its reckless attacks," he added.

Russia's nuclear agency Rosatom took over the plant in Ukraine's Zaporizhzhia, Europe's biggest civilian nuclear power complex, after it was occupied by Russia. The plant is now in shutdown mode.

Including Zaporizhzhia, Ukraine has four nuclear power plants, which are vital for the country's power supplies.

The 1986 explosion at Chernobyl was the worst civilian nuclear disaster in history and changed global perceptions of atomic energy.

Mali Minister killed; coordinated rebel, jihadist attacks rock junta

Agence France-Presse
BAMAKO

Mali's Defence Minister died after a car bomb attack on his home on Sunday, as the Army fought a second day of battles with jihadist fighters and separatist rebels near the capital Bamako and other cities, putting the Sahel nation's ruling junta under severe pressure.

Defence Minister Sadio Camara, his second wife

and two of his grandchildren died after a car bomb attack on his home in the junta stronghold of Kita, his family said.

Saturday's shock attacks, synchronised by Tuareg rebels of the Azawad Liberation Front (FLA) coalition and the jihadist Group for the Support of Islam and Muslims (JNIM), targeted several areas in the vast arid country.

Tuareg rebels said it allowed Russian forces back-

ing Mali's Army to withdraw from the city of Kidal, which they claimed was under their control.

Mali has been ravaged for more than a decade by internal conflict but Saturday's attacks were the worst since 2020, when the junta seized power.

United Nations chief Antonio Guterres condemned the "acts of violence" and called for international support to meet humanitarian needs.

**Maharashtra University Of Health Sciences, Nashik**
Dindori Road, Mhasrul, Nashik-422004
Phone No. 0253-2539236
Email: registrar@muhs.ac.in, civil@muhs.ac.in, Website: http://www.muhs.ac.in

E-tender Notice No-Civil/ 02/2026

Maharashtra University of Health Sciences invites e-tenders for providing temporary services of skilled and unskilled manpower by the contractor on contractual basis for Housekeeping Services in MUHS Campus, Nashik for a period of two years.

The e-tender form, form fee, earnest money, terms and conditions are published on the website <http://mahatenders.gov.in> The actual work should be inspected before submitting the e-tender.

Date: 27.04.2026

Sd/-
Registrar

**MAHATRANSCO**
Maharashtra State Electricity Transmission Co. Ltd.

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MSETCL invites offers by SRM e-tendering in TWO bid system (Techno-Commercial Bid and Price Bid) from the eligible registered bidders for the following work as detailed below.
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Interested bidders may obtain further information available on the website. <https://srmetender.mahatransco.in>
The date of downloading of Bid documents available on the website is from **23.04.2026**.

Sd/-
Chief Engineer (Projects), MSETCL

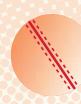
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A LANDMARK

Samson scores 5,000 runs in the IPL, enters an elite club



FILE PHOTO: EMMANUAL YOGINI

Chennai Super Kings wicketkeeper-batter Sanju Samson breached the 5,000-run mark in IPL in the match against Gujarat Titans in Chennai on Sunday. He is the 10th batter to achieve the feat and his tally includes five hundreds and 26 half-centuries. Virat Kohli and Rohit Sharma lead the run-scorers list.

SLOW BURN

Ruturaj ties with Dwayne Bravo for second-most dot balls played



R. RAGU

The 30 dot balls played out by Ruturaj Gaikwad on Sunday is the joint second-most by a batter in an innings in the IPL. Dwayne Bravo also failed to score off 30 deliveries during his unbeaten 70 off 59 for MI against KXIP in 2009. Shikhar Dhawan (PBKS) holds the record for the most dot balls (31 vs. Sunrisers Hyderabad, 2023).

BIZARRE

Raghuvanshi is the fourth to be dismissed Obstructing The Field



R.V. MOORTHY

Angkrish Raghuvanshi became the fourth player to be dismissed Obstructing The Field in the IPL. Yusuf Pathan was the first (Kolkata Knight Riders vs. Pune Warriors India, 2013), followed by Amit Mishra (Delhi Capitals vs. Sunrisers Hyderabad, 2019) and Ravindra Jadeja (Chennai Super Kings vs. Rajasthan Royals, 2024).

REAPING THE FRUITS

Mohsin says he worked a lot on fitness in the off-season



R.V. MOORTHY

I worked a lot (on my fitness) in the off-season. Body feels good and everything feels nice. Felt the slower one could be useful. I am working on my body and want to stay fit and healthy, and keep playing matches — LSG's left-arm pacer Mohsin Khan after his five-wicket haul against KKR on Sunday.

Rabada and Sai Sudharsan hog the limelight as Titans tame Super Kings

The pacer, along with new-ball partner Siraj, restricts the home team to 158 for seven; the left-handed opener makes it a cakewalk for the visitor with a 46-ball 87; skipper Ruturaj wages a lone battle for the Chennai outfit on an uneven wicket; the Men in Yellow play out a staggering 66 dot balls

IPL-19

S. Dipak Ragav
CHENNAI

A day after 986 runs were scored in the two IPL matches played in Delhi (Delhi Capitals vs. Punjab Kings) and Jaipur (Rajasthan Royals vs. Sunrisers Hyderabad), Sunday's fixture between Chennai Super Kings and Gujarat Titans felt like a palate cleanser for fans who were recovering from the gluttony of fours and sixes they were served.

In a game that seemed like an aberration in the world of T20 cricket, the Titans bowlers, especially the pacers, had the Super Kings batters hopping on a challenging surface and set up a comfortable eight-wicket win for their side here at the M.A. Chidambaram Stadium.

Opting to field, Kagiso Rabada (4-0-25-3) and Mohammed Siraj (4-0-23-1) produced a superb display of accurate fast bowling in the PowerPlay to restrict the Super Kings to a modest total of 158 for seven. For CSK, Ruturaj Gaikwad waged a lone battle, scoring an unbeaten 74 (60b, 6x4, 4x6) on a two-paced pitch.

Titans' pursuit was guided by local boy B. Sai Sudharsan, who backed up his century from the previous game with a fine 87 (46b, 4x4, 7x6). The left-hander drove well, pulled the half-trackers over the ropes and



Showing the way: Sai Sudharsan took control of the chase after Rabada pushed Super Kings on the back foot. R. RAGU & PTI

chipped away at the target meticulously.

Once he crossed 50, Sai Sudharsan floored the pedal, smacking five out of his seven sixes as Shubman Gill's men cantered home in 16.4 overs. The fate of the contest, though, was sealed in the afternoon

when Rabada broke the back of the host's batting in the PowerPlay (3-0-16-2).

The South African had the in-form Sanju Samson caught behind, and three balls later, dismissed Urvil Patel.

Siraj then inflicted further damage when he



bounced out Impact Player Sarfaraz Khan for a golden duck. From there, the runs just dried up for CSK, who crawled to 28 for three at the end of six overs.

For a period of 31 balls, there were no boundaries, and the Men in Yellow played out a staggering 66

dot balls, including 38 in the first half.

Ruturaj accelerated towards the end, scoring his last 54 runs off just 23 balls. But by then, the damage had been done for the five-time champion, which slumped to its fifth defeat in eight matches.

SCOREBOARD

CHENNAI SUPER KINGS
Sanju Samson c Buttler b Rabada 11 (15b, 2x4), Ruturaj Gaikwad (not out) 74 (60b, 6x4, 4x6), Urvil Patel c Holder b Rabada 4 (3b, 1x4), Sarfaraz Khan (Impact Player for Urvil) c Buttler b Siraj 0 (1b), Dewald Brevis c Gill b Suthar 2 (9b), Shivam Dube b Arshad 22 (17b, 3x4, 1x6), Kartik Sharma c Holder b Rabada 15 (9b, 3x4), Jamie Overton c Shahrukh b Arshad 18 (6b, 3x4, 1x6), Akeal Hosein (not out) 0 (0b); Extras (lb-2, w-10): 12; Total (for seven wkts. in 20 overs): 158.

FALL OF WICKETS
1-21 (Samson, 3.3 overs), 2-25 (Urvil, 3.6), 3-26 (Sarfaraz, 4.4), 4-37 (Brevis, 8.2), 5-96 (Dube, 15.3), 6-122 (Kartik, 17.5), 7-143 (Overton, 18.6).

TITANS BOWLING
Siraj 4-0-23-1, Rabada 4-0-25-3, Suthar 3-0-22-1, Holder 4-0-22-0, Arshad 4-0-43-2, Rashid 1-0-21-0.

GUJARAT TITANS
B. Sai Sudharsan c Brevis b Akeal 87 (46b, 4x4, 7x6), Shubman Gill st. Samson b Noor 33 (23b, 1x4, 3x6), Jos Buttler (not out) 39 (30b, 4x4, 1x6), Washington Sundar (not out) 1 (1b); Extras (w-2): 2; Total (for two wkts. in 16.4 overs): 162.

FALL OF WICKETS
1-58 (Gill, 6.2), 2-155 (Sai Sudharsan, 16.2).

SUPER KINGS BOWLING
Akeal 3-4-0-46-1, Kamboj 3-0-16-0, Overton 2-0-28-0, Gurjapneet 3-0-36-0, Noor 4-0-29-1, Dube 1-0-7-0.

Toss: Gujarat Titans.

Player-of-the-Match: Rabada. Titans won by eight wickets with 20 balls remaining.

Next assignment

GT: April 30 vs. RCB
Ahmedabad, 7.30 p.m.

CSK: May 2 vs. MI
Chennai, 7.30 p.m.

Points table

	M	W	L	NR	PTS	NRR
Punjab Kings	7	6	0	1	13	1.333
Royal Challengers	7	5	2	0	10	1.101
Sunrisers Hyderabad	8	5	3	0	10	0.815
Rajasthan Royals	8	5	3	0	10	0.602
Gujarat Titans	8	4	4	0	8	-0.475
Chennai Super Kings	8	3	5	0	6	-0.121
Delhi Capitals	7	3	4	0	6	-0.184
Kolkata Knight Riders	8	2	5	1	5	-0.751
Mumbai Indians	7	2	5	0	4	-0.736
Lucknow Super Giants	8	2	6	0	4	-1.106

Rinku and Narine do the star turn as Knight Riders clinch Super Over thriller

Sahil Mathur
LUCKNOW

In an attempt to keep their campaigns alive, Lucknow Super Giants and Kolkata Knight Riders - two bottom-placed teams - played the first Super Over of the IPL 2026 with the visiting team ending on the right side of the result here on Sunday.

Sunil Narine removed Nicholas Pooran and Aiden Markram as Super Giants only managed one run before Rinku Singh completed the formality, finishing the game with a boundary off the first ball.

Last-ball six

The match got tied when both teams finished at 155 after Mohammed Shami hit a last-ball six off Kartik Tyagi, who was defending 16 in the final over.

None of the teams was in complete control of the game during the second innings as Super Giants lost wickets regularly, while a collective bowling effort



Field day: Rinku was in the thick of action, coming to KKR's rescue with a fighting knock and superb catching. R.V. MOORTHY

kept Knight Riders in the hunt. Rishabh Pant scored with a 38-ball 42 but didn't find much support from the rest of the batters. Impact Substitute Himmat

Singh scored 19 off 10, including two fours and a six, to bring LSG close, but KKR managed to keep itself alive when he was caught in the last over.

Impact Index

1 Gill and Sai Sudharsan, with their 19th 50-plus partnership in 40 innings, went past Rohit and Ishan (18 in 54) for the most by an Indian pair

1 Ruturaj scored the slowest half-century (49 deliveries) in the Impact Player (IP) era (since 2023)

2 Super Kings registered the second-lowest PowerPlay total (28/3) this season after Sunrisers (22/3 vs. LSG)

2 CSK used the IP option within the first four overs of a contest for the second time this season (Sarfaraz for Mhatre vs. RR)

4 Ruturaj (100) became the fourth after Dhoni (234), Raina (180) and Dube (105) to hit 100 or more sixes for CSK

8 Sai Sudharsan's 75-plus scores in his first 50 visits to the crease in the league. Only Gayle (14) has more

9 Rabada's wickets in the PowerPlay, the most this season

12 The dozen overs Super Kings took to reach 50, the slowest in this edition. It was also their second slowest to the mark (12.1 overs vs. RCB, 2011)

13 Sai Sudharsan's 50-plus scores since 2024. Kohli (17) leads the charts

3555 Sanju Samson is the third fastest (by deliveries) to 5000 runs. Only de Villiers (3288) and Warner (3554) have been quicker

Compiled by Anirudh Velamuri

Earlier, Mohsin Khan's deceptiveness outsmarted KKR batters before Rinku's solo effort took his team to a competitive total.

Rinku hit four consecutive sixes off Digvesh Rathī in the last over to take 26

runs, after hammering 17 off Mohammed Shami. The KKR vice-captain moved from 53 off 42 to finish unbeaten on 83 off 51 balls.

His innings came at the back of a poor start after being put into bat on a

black-soil surface. Mohsin had Tim Seifert caught at short cover before he deceived Ajinkya Rahane with an off-cutter. In the following over, Angkrish Raghuvanshi was adjudged obstructing the field. Mohsin returned to remove Rovman Powell.

Just when Cameron Green and Rinku looked to revive the innings, Mohsin had the former caught before completing his five-wicket haul, removing Anukul Roy for a duck.

LSG bowlers did well until the 18th over to keep the scoring rate in check before Rinku gave KKR some breathing space, enough to get his side a second win.

The week ahead: April 27: DC vs. RCB (Delhi), 7.30 p.m.; **April 28:** PBKS vs. RR (New Chandigarh), 7.30 p.m.; **April 29:** MI vs. SRH (Mumbai), 7.30 p.m.; **April 30:** GT vs. RCB (Ahmedabad), 7.30 p.m.; **May 1:** RR vs. DC (Jaipur), 7.30 p.m.; **May 2:** CSK vs. MI (Chennai), 7.30 p.m.; **May 3:** SRH vs. KKR (Hyderabad), 3.30 p.m.; **May 3:** GT vs. PBKS (Ahmedabad), 7.30 p.m.

SCOREBOARD

KOLKATA KNIGHT RIDERS
Ajinkya Rahane c Markram b Mohsin 10 (15b, 1x6), Tim Seifert c Mukul b Mohsin 0 (3b), Angkrish Raghuvanshi Obstructing The Field 9 (8b, 1x4), Cameron Green c Pant b Mohsin 34 (21b, 3x6), Rovman Powell c Pant b Mohsin 1 (4b), Rinku Singh (not out) 83 (51b, 7x4, 5x6), Anukul Roy c Badoni b Mohsin 0 (1b), Ramandeep Singh c Marsh b Linde 6 (11b), Sunil Narine (not out) 4 (6b); Extras (lb-1, w-7): 8; Total (for seven wkts. in 20 overs): 155.

FALL OF WICKETS
1-3 (Seifert, 1.6 overs), 2-16 (Rahane, 3.4), 3-27 (Raghuvanshi, 4.6), 4-31 (Powell, 6.1), 5-73 (Green, 10.5), 6-73 (Anukul, 10.6), 7-93 (Ramandeep, 14.6).

SUPER GIANTS BOWLING
Shami 4-0-34-0, Mohsin 4-1-23-5, Prince 4-0-24-0, Digvesh 4-0-46-0, Linde 2-0-18-1, Markram 2-0-9-0.

LUCKNOW SUPER GIANTS
Aiden Markram c Rinku b Green 31 (27b, 2x4, 1x6), Mitchell Marsh c Powell b Vaibhav 2 (3b), Rishabh Pant c Seifert b Narine 42 (38b, 4x4, 1x6), Nicholas Pooran c Narine b Varun 9 (12b, 1x6), Ayush Badoni c Anukul b Varun 24 (19b, 2x6), Mukul Choudhary c Rinku b Anukul 1

(2b), Himmat Singh (Impact Player for Mohsin) c Rinku b Tyagi 19 (10b, 2x4, 1x6), George Linde c Rinku b Vaibhav 8 (4b, 2x4), Mohammed Shami (not out) 11 (6b, 1x4, 1x6), Prince Yadav (not out) 0 (1b); Extras (b-2, lb-1, nb-2, w-3): 8; Total (for eight wkts. in 20 overs): 155.

FALL OF WICKETS
1-8 (Marsh, 1.1), 2-65 (Markram, 10.2), 3-78 (Pant, 12.2), 4-89 (Pooran, 13.6), 5-93 (Mukul, 15.2), 6-120 (Badoni, 17.3), 7-129 (Linde, 18.2), 8-148 (Himmat, 19.3).

KNIGHT RIDERS BOWLING
Anukul 2-0-19-1, Vaibhav 4-0-24-2, Green 2-0-12-1, Narine 4-0-23-1, Varun (Impact Player for Raghuvanshi) 4-0-33-2, Tyagi 4-0-41-1.

Toss: Super Giants.

Match tied.

Super Over: Lucknow Super Giants 1/2 in 0.3 overs lost to Kolkata Knight Riders 4/0 in 0.1 over.

Player-of-the-Match: Rinku.

Next assignment

KKR: May 3 vs. SRH
Hyderabad, 3.30 p.m.

LSG: May 4 vs. MI
Mumbai, 7.30 p.m

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You can get anything done out of me for the team

Venkatesh Iyer, despite being an IPL winner, has found opportunities tough to come by at his new team Royal Challengers Bengaluru. But the 31-year-old remains in good spirits, and considers the chance to play for RCB an important step in his cricketing development

K. MURALI KUMAR

INTERVIEW

Venkatesh Iyer

N. Sudarshan

At the Indian Premier League mini auction ahead of the 2026 edition, Venkatesh Iyer, at ₹7 crore, was Royal Challengers Bengaluru's costliest buy. But the 31-year-old has played just one out of RCB's seven games so far – as an Impact Player in the six-wicket loss to Rajasthan Royals.

To his immense credit, the all-rounder is not losing sleep over it. Defending champion RCB is a well-settled outfit, and the fact that it is currently second in the table provides very little room for tinkering.

In a way, it is representative of Venkatesh's own IPL career arc. Bought at a base price of ₹20 lakh, he played a stellar role in Kolkata Knight Riders' run to the IPL final in 2021.

The subsequent year, his value zoomed up to ₹8 crore, and he was part of KKR's IPL-winning team in 2024.

Ahead of the IPL 2025 mega auction, he was released but bought back by KKR for a whopping ₹23.5 crore. But after just one season, KKR let go of him again, and he has now found a haven at RCB.

The Madhya Pradesh cricketer spoke to the media about his journey so far, the evolution of T20 cricket, sharing a dressing room with Virat Kohli and more. Excerpts:

How has the change been from KKR to RCB? Did you take time to settle down?

Being a professional, it's my duty to blend into whatever set-up I am in. But I spent a lot of time at KKR, learnt a lot of things. I'd be lying if I say that I don't have any emotional connection to them. But as professional cricketers, you are signing up for this. Whenever you enter an auction, there is an opportunity for you to play for any team. In this case, I am extremely happy to play for RCB because who does not want to. With the kind of fans, the atmosphere at Chinnaswamy [Stadium], to share a dressing room with one of the greatest icons in sporting history, and with a dear friend in the captain as well. With my skill-set, I know that I can contribute, and if

given an opportunity, I will put in my best.

How hard is it for someone like you, who has won the IPL and done well, to stay motivated for that one playing opportunity?

It is hard to be honest. But I'm a practical person. When I look at the team, I know that there's a realistic chance that I can be benched and that's okay. That's the beauty of this game. It shows you so many things. But it's extremely important to stay motivated because you can easily get desperate and lose your work ethic. So I train my mind in such a way that I'm going to play every game. With the Impact Player [rule], anything can happen. I've always lived my life in a way that I compare myself with where I was yesterday. I have had a great time over the past few years. I'm married now. I have a family. So all these things kind of add to it. No one can take away what I have achieved till now. At the same time, you have to keep working hard, keep creating an impact on the coaches to get that opportunity.

What's the advice you are getting from Dinesh Karthik?

DK is someone who believes in a lot of hard work because he's done that himself. His coaching agenda is based on hard preparation, and that's what he keeps us motivated through. It's important to understand it is very tough to be a batting coach and mentor in a set-up like RCB. You have someone like Virat Kohli who has achieved feats that no one can imagine. And you have a fresher in the form of a Vihaan Malhotra walking in. DK has to take care of both, and the overseas players. Working with him, one thing I've understood is how to be flexible when it comes to your batting – how I can assess situations, be smart in terms of staying ahead of others, and combine that with total hard work. Then, the results will take care of themselves. And even if they don't, there won't be any regret.

One year you go for ₹23 crore, then you are let go of, and then you are picked up for ₹7 crore by another franchise. How easy or hard is it to process all of this?

There will be days when you think if I had a good year last season, my bank

account would go up by another 24 crores. But you're signing up for it. There was amazing communication between me and Abhishek Nayar [at KKR], who wanted to release me. He told me what the team required, and you can get anything done out of me if it's good for the team. When I hang up my boots, all I would think about is how many titles my team won.

People won't remember records. Some may, but only from the cricketing fraternity, not those in your society. In Indore, there is a place called Rajwada. When RCB won last year, people were dancing there. It goes to show how important the victory of a team is. When I got released [from KKR], I did feel bad. Money is money. But as long as I understood that it was going to be better for the team, I had to be okay with it.

At KKR, you first had a lot of success opening. Then you shifted a bit down. Did that have an impact?

I've had very good records batting in the middle-order as well. I had a couple of 400-plus seasons (404 runs in 2023 and 370 in 2024). I've even batted at No. 8. I've never had a preferred batting position, but Brendon McCullum pushed me to open. If you choose to bat in a particular position and there's no vacancy there, you're pushing yourself into a corner. That's something that I don't want to do because I believe in contributing in multiple facets of the game. If you restrict yourself to one, you've got to be bloody good at it. And that doesn't necessarily happen. So I want to give myself the maximum opportunity to contribute to the team, be it by batting at the top, in the middle, bowling a few overs, in leadership, or fielding.

What are your learnings from sharing a dressing room with Kohli?

He is extremely down to earth and humble. He's got that aura around him which never ceases to amaze

people. It's an opportunity for you to take as many things from him as possible. Because, the situations that you have faced in life, that person has seen it 50 times more. Not just about the game, but fame, money, family. To see a complete person like that is nothing but inspiration. You see how he celebrates every wicket. You see him running. You never see him jogging on the field. He sprints. That's all the more reason for you to increase your fitness, intensity and be on top of your game. Virat Kohli improves each and every individual in the team through his actions.

T20 cricket has evolved. At RCB, what are the kinds of conversations that you have had about adding to your skill-set?

The game has definitely changed from when I started to where it is right now. You're seeing big scores. And you're seeing bowlers bringing in new types of deliveries. But one thing that hasn't

changed is the way the game is being assessed. If you're smart, then you'll be assessing the game differently. Every team has amazing talent. Six-hitters, conventional cricketers, fast bowlers, spinners, fielders, captains, you name it. One thing that will always keep you ahead is how smart you are and how you adapt to pressure. And that is what the conversation is all about – how to assess quickly and how to adapt to the conditions.

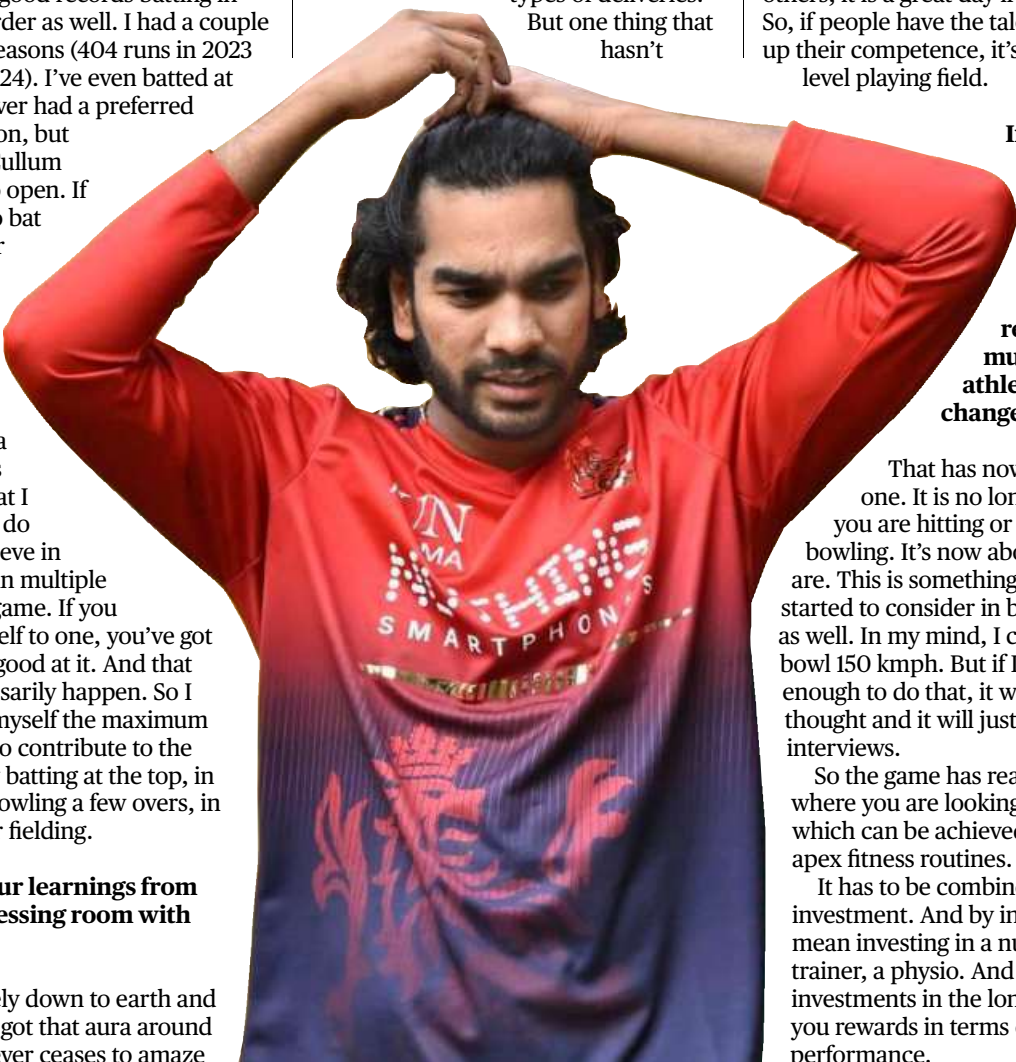
A lot of runs are being scored, so there's more pressure on bowlers to defend. But everyone is working extremely hard to hit those fours and sixes. People easily say 'It has now become a batter's game, that they are scoring 230 and 240 every time'. But there is so much hard work behind hitting those boundaries and sixes. People spend so much time practising. I always give this example: No one has been able to decode Sunil Narine till now. He's still bowling four overs for 30 runs. On his worst day, he gives 40. For others, it is a great day if they go at 40. So, if people have the talent, and keep up their competence, it's definitely a level playing field.

In terms of evolution, we are seeing relay catches more regularly. How much has elite athleticism changed things?

That has now become step one. It is no longer about how you are hitting or how you are bowling. It's now about how fit you are. This is something people have started to consider in basic coaching as well. In my mind, I can actually bowl 150 kmph. But if I am not fit enough to do that, it will just be a thought and it will just be in the interviews.

So the game has reached a point where you are looking at potential which can be achieved only through apex fitness routines.

It has to be combined with investment. And by investment, I mean investing in a nutritionist, a trainer, a physio. And those investments in the long run will give you rewards in terms of your performance.



How AI helped community-led development in Rajasthan

A project to improve water resilience in two Rajasthan districts strengthened existing government efforts by using AI to improve last-mile responsiveness; the application was also lightweight enough to sit inside any large programme that depends on frontline behaviour change and local coordination

Suchiradipta Bhattacharjee
Alan Nicol

India is in an artificial intelligence (AI) moment. Across agriculture, health, finance, and governance, the race is on to deploy AI-enabled services that reach the last mile. Chatbots answer farmer queries. Agentic tools navigate entitlement schemes. And advisory platforms push the right information to the right person (presumably) at the right time.

Many of these tools share a similar logic. While exceptions exist, they are often designed around the assumption that communities have an information deficit that AI can fill. But what if that's not all communities need?

In public services, the gap is not always between people and information. It is often between people and the local institutions meant to serve them. India's villages are shaped by the complexities of caste, class, gender, and land ownership. Numbers alone cannot track what actually makes an intervention work. Why a volunteer stops showing up, what makes a woman hesitate to speak in a Gram Sabha, and why an approved plan isn't being implemented rarely makes it back to the people designing and funding these programmes.

This is not because institutions don't want qualitative information. In many cases, they simply lack the means, time, and resources to consistently gather it at scale.

Different question for AI

The authors designed a pilot project, called AI4WaterPolicy, in the water-stressed Sirohi and Pali districts of Rajasthan. And rather than deploy AI to push information outwards, the project used it to listen.

Working with a field partner, Centre for Microfinance (CmF), and technology partner Colectiv, an AI model conducted 352 interviews across 50 villages in six months. The team had trained the model using a brief of the programme context and the questions it needed to know.

The AI chatbot then held 20-minute WhatsApp conversations in Hindi and local dialects via voice notes or text with 'Pani Mitras' (community volunteer water champions), Panchayat leaders, and CmF's frontline staff. Follow-up questions were adapted to each respondent on the fly. The model finally translated anonymised transcripts and organised them thematically, after which the field and research team reviewed and validated them.

The answers revealed three things:

(i) **Pride in the results:** "Water level in my village, which was at 150 feet, has now come to below 100 feet. This is a matter of great pride for me";

(ii) **The double burden for women:** "I manage my family by waking up early,



Technology must empower the human intermediary, like the community volunteer water champions in the AI4WaterPolicy project, rather than replace them. GETTY IMAGES

then I visit other women in the village to discuss water-related issues. After returning home, I resume my household work"; and

(iii) **Funding and approval delays:** "Because of delayed approval of proposals in the Panchayat department, we could not complete the work on time"

The project then deployed 'Pani Mitras' to address these issues. During the project's structured workshops to share and discuss findings with respondents, called 'Pause and Reflect' sessions, participants validated some interpretations and pushed back on others. Mainly, they said their limited understanding of Panchayat procedures and government schemes was a challenge.

In reply, CmF redesigned its training programme mid-cycle to add a Panchayati Raj orientation programme and structured workshops with block-level officials from rural development, agriculture, and water resources departments. This pivot was not part of the original plan. It happened because the AI model helped the project turn insights around quickly enough to act within the same programme cycle.

Follow-up interviews with 'Pani Mitras' three months after the workshops found that more than half of the community members had since engaged directly with government officials – something many had hesitated to do before.

They reported more confidence navigating scheme application processes and mentioned the feedback had prompted their Panchayat or department

The AI4WaterPolicy pilot succeeded not just because of the algorithms used but also because its organisers budgeted time, funds, and people to return findings to respondents and co-develop follow-up actions

to act more quickly.

Listening with intent

There is an important distinction here: responsive systems and actively listening systems are not the same thing. The former takes community input as a signal and returns an answer. The latter is shaped by what it hears and the community moves from being a passive beneficiary to an active co-designer.

In this pilot, AI made active listening possible in three ways. First, a voice-enabled WhatsApp channel gave 'Pani Mitras' a private space to speak freely. As one respondent put it, "When a person is in front of you, you feel hesitant. On your own phone, there's no hesitation." Second, the AI model identified recurring themes across 352 conversations without requiring weeks of manual coding. Third, because the findings were synthesised within weeks, the implementing team could redesign training mid-cycle. Traditional monitoring can't easily provide such responsiveness.

The AI4WaterPolicy pilot succeeded not just because of the algorithms used but also because its organisers budgeted time, funds, and people to return findings

to respondents and co-develop follow-up actions. CmF had also spent years working in these villages, identifying and training the 'Pani Mitras'. During the interviews, their staff facilitated access to shared devices for participants without smartphones, helped navigate connectivity problems, and ensured the 'Pause and Reflect' sessions were genuine deliberations. The AI could listen at scale precisely because human relationships had already created the conditions necessary for honest conversations.

Empower, not replace

The digital divide is real and manifests in gender, class, and caste-based differences, and any honest conversation about AI and the last mile must reckon with this reality. Technology must empower the human intermediary, like the 'Pani Mitras', rather than replace them. This was not a one-off pilot from Rajasthan. The approach strengthened and complemented existing government efforts by enhancing feedback loops and improving last-mile responsiveness. It was also lightweight enough to sit inside any large programme that depends on frontline behaviour change and local coordination.

Policies, programmes, and systems like Jal Jeevan Mission, VB-G RAM G, and sectoral extension systems all include such last-mile implementation.

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THE GIST

The authors designed a pilot project, called AI4WaterPolicy, in the water-stressed Sirohi and Pali districts of Rajasthan

The AI chatbot held 20-minute WhatsApp conversations in Hindi and local dialects via voice notes or text with 'Pani Mitras' (community volunteer water champions), Panchayat leaders, and CmF's frontline staff

The AI could listen at scale precisely because human relationships had already created the conditions necessary for honest conversations

BIG SHOT



A view of the reactor core mimic display, a.k.a. the mnemonic table, that was part of the SKALA computer system at the Chernobyl nuclear power plant. By looking at the coloured tiles on the display, operators could quickly understand the distribution of activity across the core, helping them balance the reactor's power output and identify where heat was building up. AFP

QUESTION CORNER

Neanderthal mystery



Q: How did the Neanderthals go extinct?

A: Pursuing the mystery of how the Neanderthals went extinct, researchers from the Universities of

Cambridge and of Montreal have now asserted that climate change was not the primary reason. Instead, they have reported that *Homo sapiens* succeeded because of their better social connectivity whereas the Neanderthals' populations suffered the effects of poor social connections.

The findings, published on April 1 *Quaternary Science Reviews*, were based on habitat suitability modelling: using algorithms to estimate where ancient humans might have preferred to live based on simulations of the climate over 60,000 years.

Based on these simulations, the team said that both species maintained "core" regions in Spain and Italy, among other areas, that should have provided shelter and protection as the populations negotiated Marine Isotope Stage 3 — a time when the earth was cold even as its climate oscillated rapidly.

The researchers also said that these two groups rarely crossed paths: based on their estimated maps, the researchers said the species' ranges overlapped by less than 5% — a figure they said weakened the theory of "competitive



Scientist Svante Pääbo poses with a replica of a Neanderthal skeleton on October 3, 2022. AP

exclusion", which claims that Neanderthals went extinct because *H. sapiens* outcompeted them for resources.

If the new findings are to be believed, Neanderthal groups in Eastern Europe were too isolated to survive demographic pressures, while *H. sapiens* benefited from superior networks along coastal migration routes. Ultimately, the paper concluded, the process in which *H. sapiens* replaced Neanderthals was "regionally differentiated", meaning it happened for different reasons in different locations.



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Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Number of Lebanese towns asked to be evacuated by Israel

7 Israel's military issued evacuation orders for southern Lebanon on Sunday, ordering residents to leave seven towns that lie beyond the "buffer zone" it occupied before a ceasefire that has failed to bring a full halt to hostilities. A spokesperson for the Israeli military said that Lebanese armed group Hezbollah was violating the ceasefire and that Israel would act against it. REUTERS

Motorists penalised by Delhi Police during enforcement drive

11,800 The Delhi Traffic Police penalised over 11,800 motorists during a special three-hour enforcement drive conducted across the city, officials said. The intensive drive was carried out on Saturday across all traffic ranges and districts as part of efforts to curb congestion and enhance road safety. PTI

Area burned by the Otsuchi fires in Japan as of Sunday morning

1,373 hectares. Japan has deployed 1,400 firefighters and dozens of Self-Defence Force personnel to battle mountain blazes that have been raging in the north for five days, officials said on Sunday. Two more wildfires broke out elsewhere in the north — one in Kitakata city and the other in Nagaoka. PTI

Value of projects proposed by the Himachal government

5,400 in ₹ crore. Himachal Pradesh government has proposed projects of over ₹5,400 crore under the Urban Challenge Fund, said Public Works and Urban Development Minister Vikramaditya Singh. In a meeting held in Delhi, he requested earmarking of ₹1,350 crore for the State as the Centre's share, a statement said. PTI

E-checkposts in coal-rich Singrauli to curb illegal transport

3 Three AI-powered e-checkposts have been installed in the coal-rich Singrauli district of Madhya Pradesh to curb illegal transportation of minerals, enhance revenue and improve transparency, officials said on Sunday. Singrauli, situated in the northeast of MP close to Uttar Pradesh, is widely known as the "Energy Capital of India". PTI
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SIR pause on way to a billion electorate

The SIR has trimmed India's electoral roll by removing absent, shifted, dead, and duplicate names, leading to record turnout percentages across States despite shrunkn electorates; while the exercise strengthens the accuracy of the roll, the challenge now is to ensure it remains inclusive and free of disenfranchisement

FULL CONTEXT

Akshay Rout

Tamil Nadu finished its single-day poll on April 23 with a record turnout of over 85%, surpassing the earlier best of 78.29% in 2011 and a huge 12% higher than the 73.63% turnout in the last Assembly election. The base for the turnout was a trimmed-down electorate of 5.67 crore. While factoring in the high-octane political contest and mobilisation, the turnout rate would arguably be lower if the State electoral roll had retained "ghost electors" – the dead, shifted, absent, and duplicate names – that existed as of October 2025, when the special intensive revision (SIR) kicked in. Similar trend is seen in West Bengal, with a turnout of 92.88% in the first phase. Assam, Puducherry, and Kerala also delivered record turnouts earlier this month, all following the pattern of shrunkn electorates. Therein lies a story.

Before the turn

In the run-up to its 75th Foundation Day on January 25 last year, also called the National Voters' Day, the Election Commission (EC) announced a grand celebration 'in light of the fact that India's total electorate is approaching the 100-crore mark.' That was a well-made observation by available arithmetic. The electoral database then stood at 99.1 crore, including 21.7 crore young voters aged 18-29. The steadily rising electoral gender ratio had further jumped from 948 in 2024 to 954. With an estimated population of 1.4 billion, India went into the last Lok Sabha elections with 96.88 crore registered voters. International observers have long watched in awe the elephantine Indian electorate, with the United States a distant second and countries such as Brazil and Indonesia trailing far behind. As the SIR completed its second phase earlier this month, India's grand list of electors appears poised to be significantly reversing its advance, though it may still be celebrated for other reasons.

India's electorate has been growing constantly, keeping pace with population growth. The logic is simple: all citizens above the age of 18, unless otherwise disqualified, are to be included in the electoral roll of their respective constituencies, where they are ordinarily resident. Broadly estimated at 75% of the population, a billion voters would look natural in the case of a wholesome registration. Interestingly, the electorate has often grown faster; during the 1951-2021 period, the population grew fourfold, from 36 crore to 138 crore, while the electorate grew more than fivefold, from 17 crore to 91 crore.

Starting with 17.32 crore electors in 1951, India's electoral roll has swelled steadily year after year, except for minor aberrations after accounting for births and deaths by lakhs of ground-level staff. Each January, the country releases updated and revised electoral rolls based on a summary revision with reference to 1st January.

The SIR twist

But then came SIR 2025. The revision, which has already covered 13 States and Union Territories, including Bihar in the first phase, has disrupted the usual elector count based on the logic of growing population. In the 12 States and Union Territories where SIR was ordered on October 27 last year – spanning 321



A voter checks his name on the electoral roll after the Election Commission published West Bengal's post-SIR voter list in Kolkata on February 28. PTI

The SIR is not the answer to the alleged adulteration of demography by non-citizens or infiltrators, nor is the EC in charge of policing this part. But, SIR has cured the electoral roll of its obesity, giving it a new look

districts and 1,843 Assembly constituencies – the number of electors has dropped to less than 46 crore from a base of 51 crore. All major States, such as Uttar Pradesh, Tamil Nadu, West Bengal, Gujarat, and Chhattisgarh, have each reported a reduction of more than 10%.

Much of the downsizing is due to the removal of ASDD names (absent, shifted, dead, or doubly enrolled), purification being a basic purpose of any electoral revision. States such as Uttar Pradesh and Bihar have a history of job-related migration, warranting the removal of names. The ASDD burden has also accumulated because the last SIR was conducted between 2002 and 2004.

In substantial consideration, SIR entails drafting a new roll, compared to annual revisions, which are corrections on the existing list. But notably, there are a sizable number of deletions on account of non-return of enumeration forms, non-traceability of persons, objections received through the designated Form 7, and, importantly, for failing the eligibility criteria stipulated for electors under the Constitution, determined through verification of documents.

With the burden of proof shifting to the citizen, for a sizeable section of the population, the SIR has been like re-earning the franchise.

Additions factored

During the SIR process, the trimming is most visible at the draft roll stage and is largely driven by ASDD factors. There is,

however, some recovery on the way to the final roll, thanks to fresh enrolments. In Uttar Pradesh, the initial roll of 15.44 crore slumped to a draft of 12.55 crore, before rising to a final tally of 13.39 crore following substantial additions. Tamil Nadu started with a list of 6.41 crore, which fell to 5.44 crore in the draft roll, but the net final roll was of 5.67 crore electors.

In June last year, Bihar started the intensive revision with a base of 7.89 crore electors and ended up with a final roll of 7.42 crore, improving upon the published draft of 7.24 crore. West Bengal, however, has been a different case, with issues of logical discrepancies affecting the final roll and spilling over into politics and the streets.

Reverse journey

Close to 60 crore of India's electors have already gone through the SIR exercise. The aggregate number has declined by nearly six crores even after additions. The remaining 40 crore electors, spread across 23 States and U.T.s, are now preparing for the scrutiny. With standard extrapolation, by the time SIR is completed across the country, the size of India's electorate could fall to around 90 crore.

The stated goal of SIR is to ensure that all eligible citizens, including newly eligible youth and temporary migrants, are included in the electoral roll. The details of the post-SIR final rolls, especially the addition of new electors, bear testimony to this effort. But the activity missed the profile, drowned in the overwhelming narrative of deletion.

In recent years, inclusivity has been a key focus in electoral roll management, addressing gender disparities, improving youth cohorts, and ensuring that persons with disabilities, the third gender community, and Particularly Vulnerable Tribal Groups (PVTG) are fully enrolled in

a campaign mode.

Crux of democracy

India has prided itself on both the scale and quality of its elections over the last 75 years. The starting manifestation of both these is in the country's electoral roll. The litmus test for a credible election begins with the accuracy and completeness of the electoral roll and culminates in the general acceptance of the electoral outcome. Despite the scepticism from Western powers at the dawn of India's independence, the country has stood firm in sustaining an electoral democracy through credible and respectful exercise of the franchise. This is an outstanding fact, irrespective of the recent disputes over the electoral process and management. All interventions, including SIR, have to strengthen the cause.

Renew focus on inclusion

The SIR is not the answer to the alleged adulteration of demography by non-citizens or infiltrators, nor is the EC in charge of policing this part. However, the SIR has cured the electoral roll of its obesity, giving it a new look. The quantitative expansion of India's electoral roll has received a discernible pause.

It is now for election managers to ensure and provide all stakeholders with the confidence that the new slim roll is accurate and free of disenfranchisement. Concerns that the SIR process, in its uncompromising pursuit, should not strip people and groups of their democratic rights on technical grounds must not be seen as hostile.

After the high-profile focus on removing ineligible names, the EC should now invest its energy in reaffirming its celebrated resolve that no eligible voter is left behind.

(Akshay Rout is former Director General, Election Commission of India. Views expressed are personal)

THE GIST

India's electorate, which had steadily expanded faster than population growth, is now poised for a reverse trajectory, with numbers potentially falling towards 90 crore as the exercise progresses across the remaining States and U.T.s.

The revision process, involving draft rolls, verification of documents, objections through Form 7, and non-return of enumeration forms, has in many cases shifted the burden of proof to citizens, making it akin to re-earning the franchise for sections of the population.

Despite the dominant narrative of deletions, final rolls show recovery through fresh enrolments, reflecting efforts to include newly eligible youth, migrants, and underrepresented groups, even as discrepancies in some States continue to spill into politics and public debate.

